

Advisor Services

Insights from the 2026 RIA Benchmarking Study



charles
SCHWAB

Schwab's RIA Benchmarking Study is the industry leader.

**1,236 firms, representing over \$2.5 trillion in AUM,
participated in the 2026 study.**

- **2026 marked the 20th year of the Benchmarking Study.**
- **Advisors responded between January and March 2026.**

This presentation is organized according to Schwab's Guiding Principles for Advisory Firm Success, a framework to help advisors address the complexities of growing their firms and creating enduring businesses.

"The RIA industry continues to demonstrate exceptional strength – growth remains strong, client retention is at a decade-high, and firms are investing in the talent and technology needed to sustain that momentum. What's shifting is how firms compete: firms that are implementing AI and streamlining digital processes are delivering the kind of consistent, high-quality experience that employees and clients have come to expect."

Lisa Salvi

*Managing Director, Business Consulting and Education
Charles Schwab Advisor Services*

Key Findings Snapshot

The RIA industry continues to be exceptionally strong, and growth remains a top priority.

- RIA firms of all sizes saw significant growth in 2025. Across the study, AUM increased 17%, revenue was up by 13.2%, and client growth was up 4.7% in 2025. (Slide 5)
- Top Performing Firms show more robust growth than all other firms which may be attributed to their greater likelihood of having foundational planning elements in place. (Slide 11)
- A decade of 97% client retention demonstrates the strength of the RIA Industry. (Slide 18)

Organic growth was integral to gains – driven by firms' value propositions and marketing strategies.

- Organic growth was an integral part of the gains seen last year as firms continued to attract investors and win more assets from existing clients. (Slide 10)
 - For firms with under \$250M, net organic growth contributed 7.2% to AUM growth.
 - For firms with over \$250M in assets, net organic growth contributed 4.8% to AUM growth.
 - For Top Performing Firms, net organic growth contributed 12.9% to overall asset growth.
- Top Performing Firms gained 4.2x more assets from existing clients and 2.8x more assets from new clients compared to all other firms in 2025. (Slides 19 and 38)
- Firms with a written marketing plan, ideal client persona, and defined value proposition continue to gain more new clients and assets (Slide 22):
 - 87% more new clients in 2025
 - 127% more new client assets in 2025

Attracting and retaining talent remains a focus for most firms to ensure their long-term growth, success, and sustainability.

- 75% of firms with \$250 million or more in AUM hired in 2025 and 75% of firms plan to hire in 2026. (Slides 44 and 45)
- Top recruiting channels used include personal and professional networks (56% of firms), colleges and universities (36% of firms), and RIAs (28% of firms). (Slide 44)
- Adoption of an employee value proposition (EVP) has grown nearly 10% over four years for firms with \$250 million or more in AUM and 62% of Top Performing Firms have an EVP. (Slide 47)

AI, technology, and digital processes are improving operational efficiencies, while delivering a consistent and secure experience for advisors and their clients.

- 83% of firms with \$250 million or more in AUM reported using some form of AI and the most common use cases include administrative tasks (65%), developing client correspondence (49%), generating market content (48%). (Slide 34)
- As firms have improved operational efficiency, they have realized productivity gains – Top Performing Firms spent about 10% less time annually per client on operations compared with all other firms. (Slide 29)
- AI has entered the hiring process to support recruitment for firms with \$250M or more in AUM, including writing job descriptions (47%), developing interview questions (35%), and creating training/onboarding materials (23%). (Slide 51)

Inorganic strategies to drive growth, acquire talent, and create scale continue to be of interest.

- Over the past five years, 35% of firms have engaged in inorganic activity. (slide 13)
 - 15% of firms have engaged in M&A
 - 19% have brought on one or more advisors with a book of business

GUIDING PRINCIPLES FOR ADVISORY FIRM SUCCESS



Effective planning
and execution is a
leading indicator
of success



Value is defined
through your
clients' eyes



Operational
excellence creates
greater capacity
for clients



Your
reputation is
your brand



People are your
most important
asset



Effective planning and execution is a leading indicator of success

Growing your firm requires focus, strategic planning, and an innovative mindset. Establishing a shared vision for the future, creating alignment, and driving effective execution power your growth engine and provide a clear understanding of the future and how you'll get there.



Value is defined through your clients' eyes

Firms thrive when focusing on the client experience from their clients' point of view. When every person, process, service offering, and system maintains an extreme focus on your ideal client, you are able to differentiate your firm in an increasingly competitive landscape.



Operational excellence creates greater capacity for clients

Institutionalizing your business through technology and operations provides operational discipline, allowing you to maximize scalability, manage risk, and build a solid infrastructure, so that you can reinvest time where it matters most—with your clients protecting the trust that you have built.



Your reputation is your brand

Every aspect of your firm—employees, centers of influence, clients, and even your digital presence—should effectively amplify your firm's reputation within the community you serve in a way that increases referrals and generates new business.



People are your most important asset

Creating a cycle of opportunity to attract and retain top talent helps ensure continuity of your firm's people, culture, and values as you prepare for the future. That's why having a high-performing and diverse team, unlocking their potential, and rewarding and developing the next generation of leadership is a long-term commitment and critical to building a legacy.

The Firm Performance Index identifies Top Performing Firms and helps advisors pinpoint strengths and opportunities.

The Firm Performance Index ranks all firms on 15 metrics that align with the Guiding Principles for Advisory Firm Success.

The index is a holistic assessment of RIA performance across key areas.

Top Performing Firms are those that rank in the top 20% of the index.

Firm performance

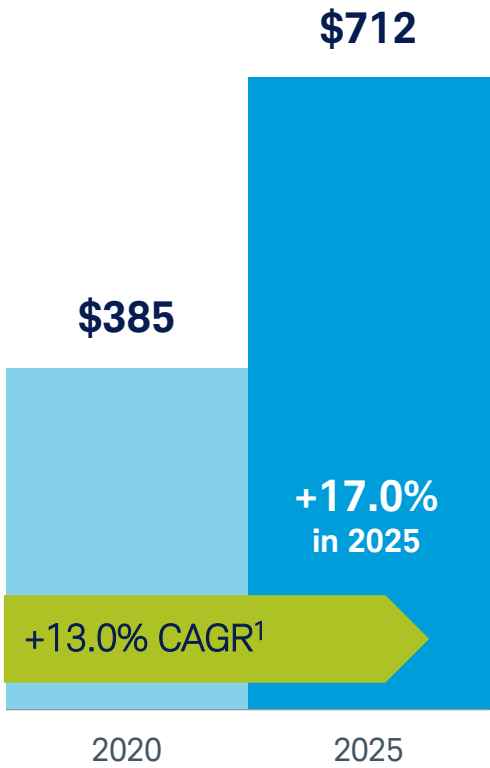
- 5-year client compound annual growth rate (CAGR)
- 5-year net asset flows CAGR
- 5-year revenue CAGR
- 2025 AUM growth rate from new client assets
- 2025 AUM growth rate from existing client assets
- Client attrition
- Staff attrition
- Operating margin (reported)
- Time spent on client service
- Time spent on operations

Activities implemented

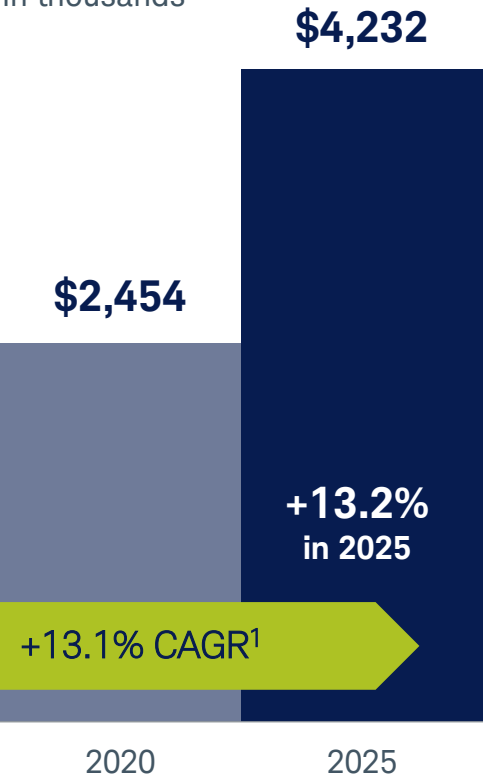
- Standardized workflows in CRM for over 50% of tasks
- Written strategic plan
- Written succession plan
- Ideal client persona/profile
- Client value proposition

Growth remained strong across the RIA industry in 2025, underscoring continued momentum.

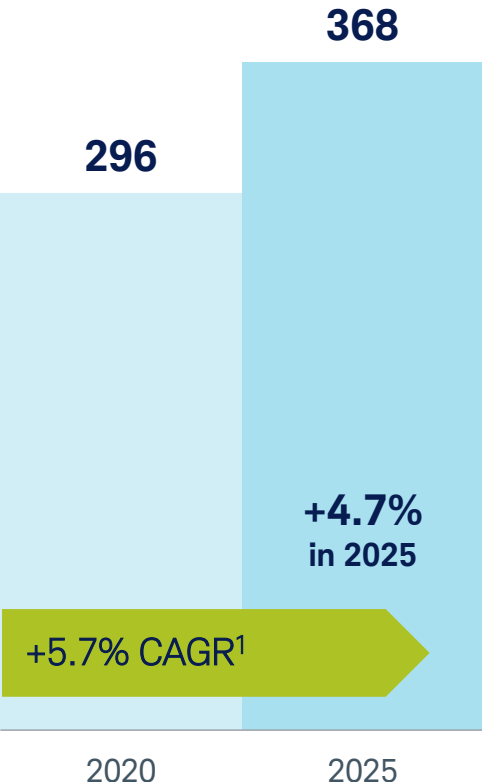
Assets under management
In millions



Revenue
In thousands



Clients



¹ Median 5-year compound annual growth rate (CAGR) over the period from year-end 2020 through 2025 for all firms with \$25 million or more in AUM.

Median results for all firms with \$25 million or more in AUM. Past performance is not an indicator of future results. 2026 RIA Benchmarking Study from Charles Schwab, fielded January to March 2026. Study contains self-reported data from 1,236 firms. Participant firms represent various sizes and business models categorized into peer groups by AUM.

Growth and adding talent continue to be top priorities, with AI ranking in the top 10.

Top strategic initiatives	Rank				
	2026	2025	2024	2023	2022
Acquire new clients through client referrals	1	1	1	1	2
Recruit staff to increase firm’s skill set/capacity	2	2	3	2	1
Acquire new clients through business referrals	3	3	2	3	3
Enhance strategic planning and execution	4	4	4	4	4
Acquire new clients through digital channels	5	6	7	7	6
Improve productivity through use of AI	6	N/A	N/A	N/A	N/A
Integrate AI into our business strategy	7	N/A	N/A	N/A	N/A

Results for all firms with \$250 million or more in AUM that selected initiative as a top 3 priority. Past performance is not an indicator of future results. 2026 RIA Benchmarking Study from Charles Schwab, fielded January to March 2026. Study contains self-reported data from 1,236 firms. Participant firms represent various sizes and business models categorized into peer groups by AUM.

AI responses only available in the 2026 RIA Benchmarking Study from Charles Schwab.

Advisors identified areas of their businesses that could benefit from outside help.

1	AI strategy	47%
2	Marketing strategy	23%
3	Growth strategy	21%
4	Back-office process improvements	21%
5	Staff development through coaching and mentoring	20%
6	Technology strategy	20%
7	Creating a digital marketing strategy	17%
8	Staff training in sales and business development	15%

AI strategy (**chosen by 47% of firms**) tops the list of advisor support needs, spotlighting the industry’s drive to harness AI effectively.

Results for all firms with \$250 million or more in AUM that selected initiative as a top 3 priority. 2026 RIA Benchmarking Study from Charles Schwab, fielded January to March 2026. Study contains self-reported data from 1,236 firms. Participant firms represent various sizes and business models categorized into peer groups by AUM.

AI responses only available in the 2026 RIA Benchmarking Study from Charles Schwab.

GUIDING PRINCIPLES FOR ADVISORY FIRM SUCCESS



Effective planning
and execution is a
leading indicator
of success



Value is defined
through your
clients' eyes



Operational
excellence creates
greater capacity
for clients



Your
reputation is
your brand



People are your
most important
asset

The value of an additional 1% in organic growth

Increases to organic growth do not need to be dramatic to make a large impact. Even small increases translate into higher AUM, expanding revenue, and, ultimately, greater enterprise value.

Valuation impact of organic growth: Earnings and multiple expansion

Based on a hypothetical firm with an AUM of \$712M and a valuation of \$14.4M in 2025.*

2030 Projected Values	7% organic growth	8% organic growth	10% organic growth
AUM (\$M)	\$1,310	\$1,366	\$1,477
Revenue (\$M)	\$7.8	\$8.6	\$9.3
Valuation (\$M)	\$26.8	\$29.3	\$31.7
Change in valuation with a constant multiple (11x)	N/A	+\$2.6M	+\$5.0M

Updated valuation with higher multiple (\$M)	\$26.8 11x multiple	\$32.0 12x multiple	\$40.4 14x multiple
Change in valuation with increasing multiple	N/A	+\$5.3M	+13.6M

* Hypothetical firm based on 2026 RIA Benchmarking Study from Charles Schwab, Fielded January to March 2026. Median AUM and revenue values and 5-year compound annual growth rates (CAGR) from year end 2020 through 2025 for all firms with \$25M or more in AUM. 2025-2030 projections based on historical 5-year CAGRS plus additional growth. Study contains self-reported data. External valuation calculation applies a multiple of earnings EBITDA method, applying a fair market value multiple of 11x over the 10-year period (with input from Advice Dynamics Partners, LLC). Illustration reflects rounding. Past performance is not an indicator of future results.

Organic growth was integral to gains, as firms' value propositions continued to attract investors.

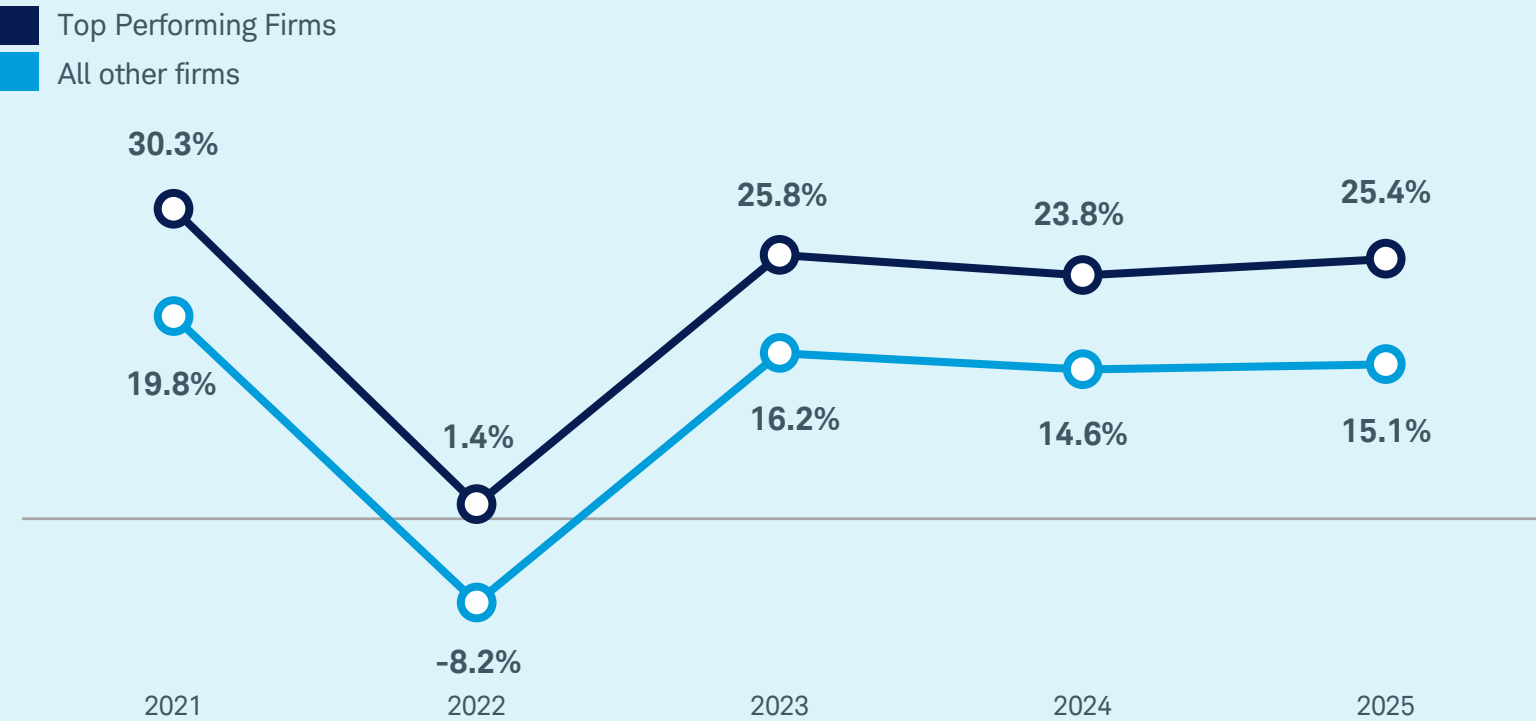
Contribution of net organic asset growth to AUM growth



Median results. Top Performing Firms are those that rank in the top 20% of the Firm Performance Index. The index evaluates all firms in the study according to 15 metrics to arrive at a holistic assessment of each firm's performance across key business areas. Past performance is not an indicator of future results. 2026 RIA Benchmarking Study from Charles Schwab, fielded January to March 2026. Study contains self-reported data from 1,236 firms. Participant firms represent various sizes and business models categorized into peer groups by AUM.

Top Performing Firms show more robust growth than all other firms.

Median AUM growth



Top Performing Firms versus all other firms

5-year CAGR¹:

AUM	2.0x
Revenue	1.9x
Clients	2.7x
Net asset flows	3.2x

¹ Median 5-year compound annual growth rate (CAGR) over the period from year-end 2020 through 2025.

Top Performing Firms are those that rank in the top 20% of the Firm Performance Index. The index evaluates all firms in the study according to 15 metrics to arrive at a holistic assessment of each firm's performance across key business areas. Past performance is not an indicator of future results. 2026 RIA Benchmarking Study from Charles Schwab, fielded January to March 2026. Study contains self-reported data from 1,236 firms. Participant firms represent various sizes and business models categorized into peer groups by AUM.

Top Performing Firms' strong long-term results and organic growth signal successful strategies.

	Top Performing Firms	All other firms	Multiple
5-year revenue CAGR	21.3%	11.3%	1.9x
5-year client CAGR	12.4%	4.6%	2.7x
5-year net asset flows CAGR	15.3%	4.7%	3.2x
Assets from existing clients in 2025	\$19.0M	\$4.5M	4.2x
Assets from new clients in 2025	\$57.7M	\$20.8M	2.8x
New revenue per client-facing staff in 2025	\$81.4K	\$41.8K	1.9x

Median results for Top Performing Firms and all other firms. Median 5-year compound annual growth rate (CAGR) over the period from year-end 2020 through 2025. Top Performing Firms are those that rank in the top 20% of the Firm Performance Index. The index evaluates all firms in the study according to 15 metrics to arrive at a holistic assessment of each firm's performance across key business areas. Past performance is not an indicator of future results. 2026 RIA Benchmarking Study from Charles Schwab, fielded January to March 2026. Study contains self-reported data from 1,236 firms. Participant firms represent various sizes and business models categorized into peer groups by AUM.

Over the past 5 years,
35% of firms have pursued
inorganic strategies.

15% of firms

have engaged in **M&A**
in the past 5 years.

19% of firms

have had an **advisor with
a book of business** join in
the past 5 years.

	Firms with inorganic activity	Firms without inorganic activity	Multiple
5-year CAGR			
AUM	15.6%	11.7%	1.3x
Revenue	15.5%	12.2%	1.3x
Clients	7.6%	4.6%	1.7x

Inorganic activity represents mergers and acquisitions, divestitures, and advisors joining or leaving over the period from 2021 through 2025. Results for all firms with \$250 million or more in AUM. Median 5-year compound annual growth rate (CAGR) over the period from year-end 2020 through 2025. Past performance is not an indicator of future results. 2026 RIA Benchmarking Study from Charles Schwab, fielded January to March 2026. Study contains self-reported data from 1,236 firms. Participant firms represent various sizes and business models categorized into peer groups by AUM.

Looking ahead, half of firms are seeking inorganic growth opportunities.

Firms actively seeking to buy another RIA



Firms actively seeking to bring on an advisor with a book of business



Firms actively seeking to bring on a principal with transferrable assets

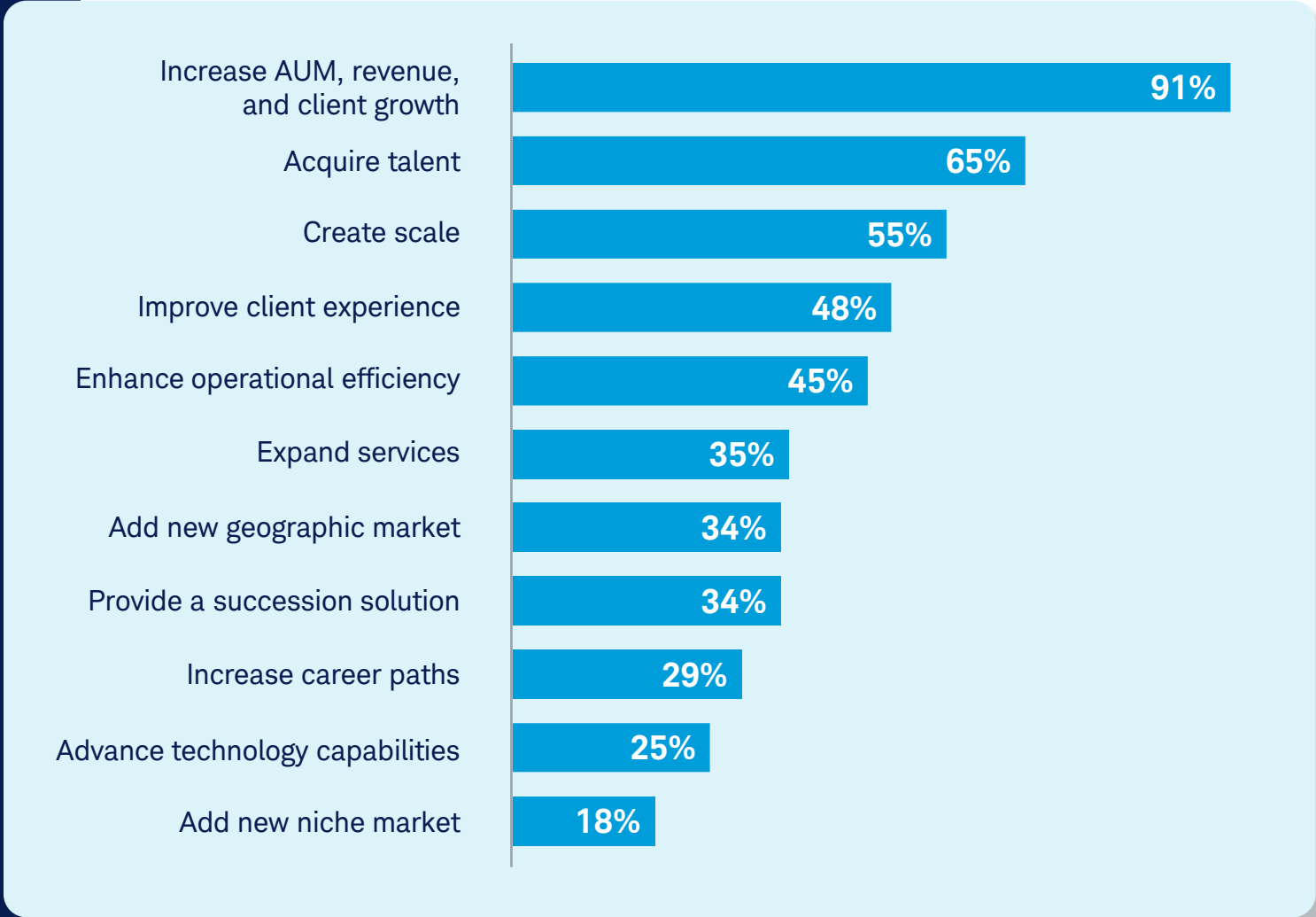


Inorganic growth is a firmwide imperative.

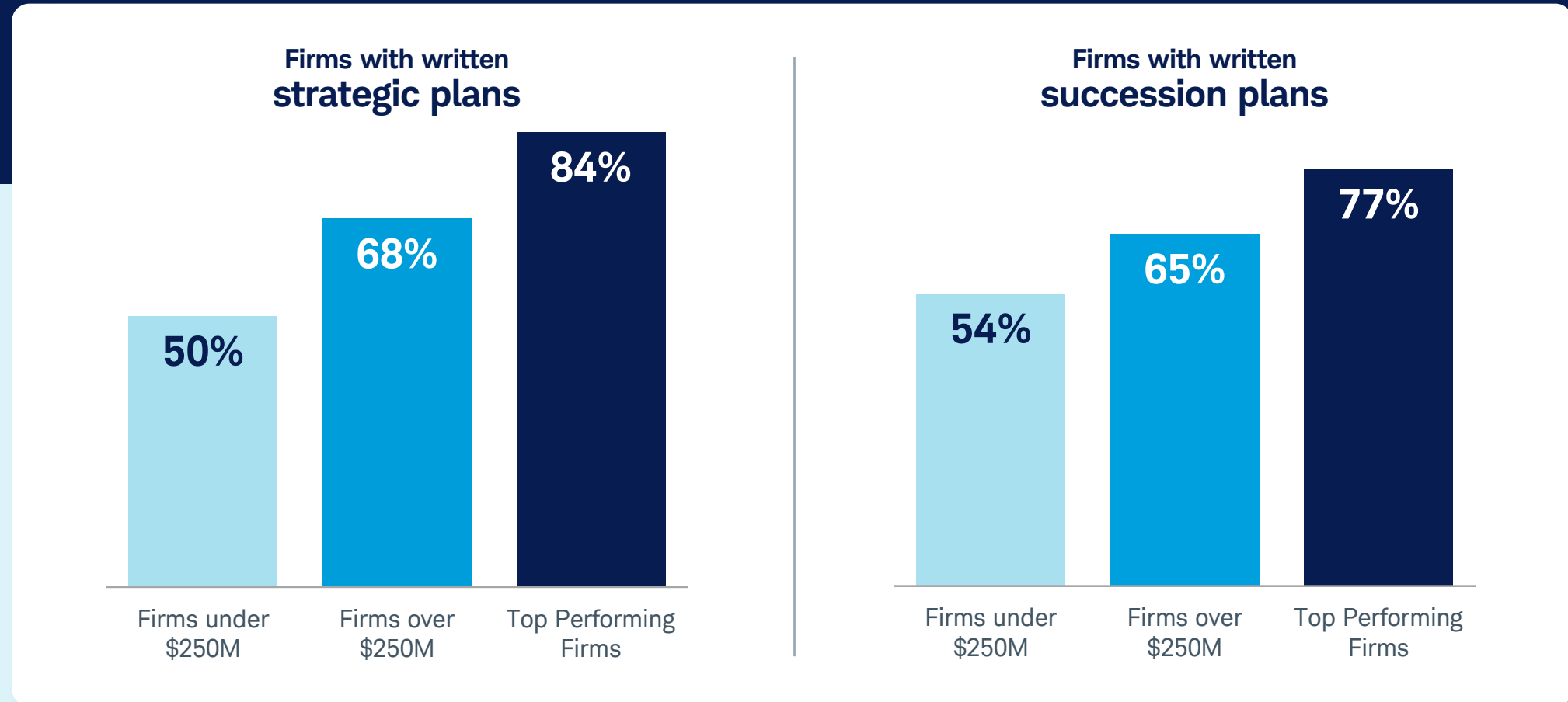


Firms pursuing inorganic strategies said their top reasons for doing so were to increase growth, acquire talent, and create scale.

Results for all firms with \$250 million or more in AUM that reported pursuing inorganic strategies. Past performance is not an indicator of future results. 2026 RIA Benchmarking Study from Charles Schwab, fielded January to March 2026. Study contains self-reported data from 1,236 firms. Participant firms represent various sizes and business models categorized into peer groups by AUM.



Strategic and succession plans are foundational to firm performance and endurance.



Top Performing Firms are those that rank in the top 20% of the Firm Performance Index. The index evaluates all firms in the study according to 15 metrics to arrive at a holistic assessment of each firm's performance across key business areas. Past performance is not an indicator of future results. 2026 RIA Benchmarking Study from Charles Schwab, fielded January to March 2026. Study contains self-reported data from 1,236 firms. Participant firms represent various sizes and business models categorized into peer groups by AUM.

GUIDING PRINCIPLES FOR ADVISORY FIRM SUCCESS



Effective planning
and execution is a
leading indicator
of success



Value is defined
through your
clients' eyes



Operational
excellence creates
greater capacity
for clients



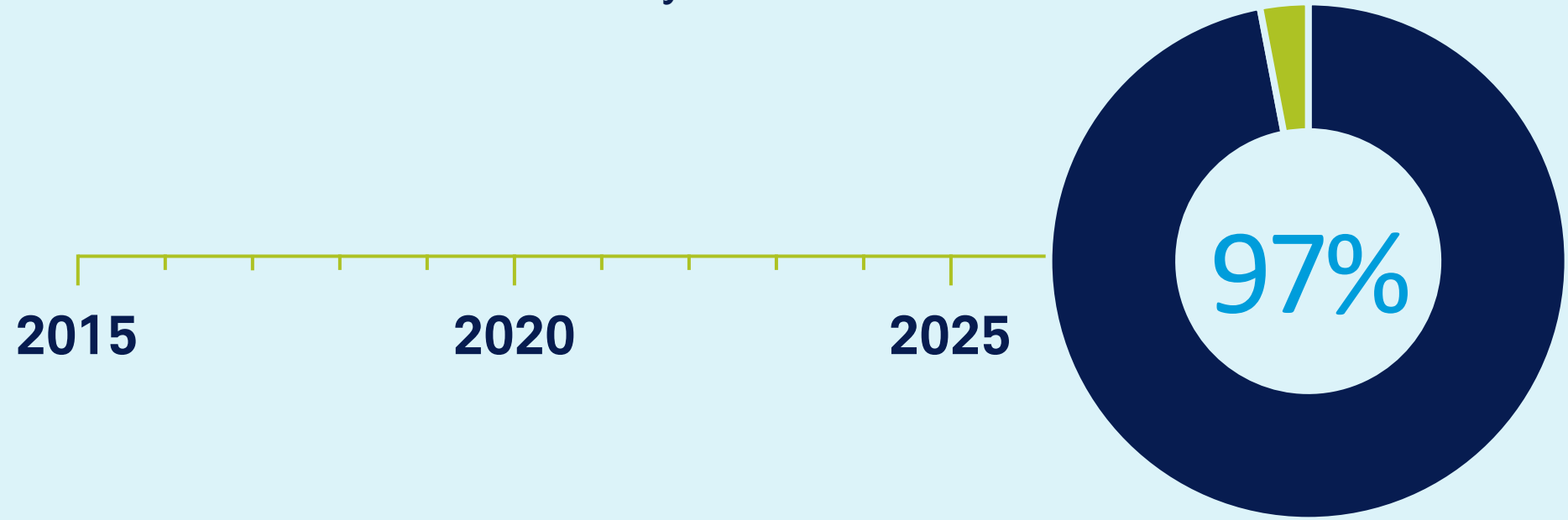
Your
reputation is
your brand



People are your
most important
asset

A decade of 97% client retention attests to the strength of the RIA industry.

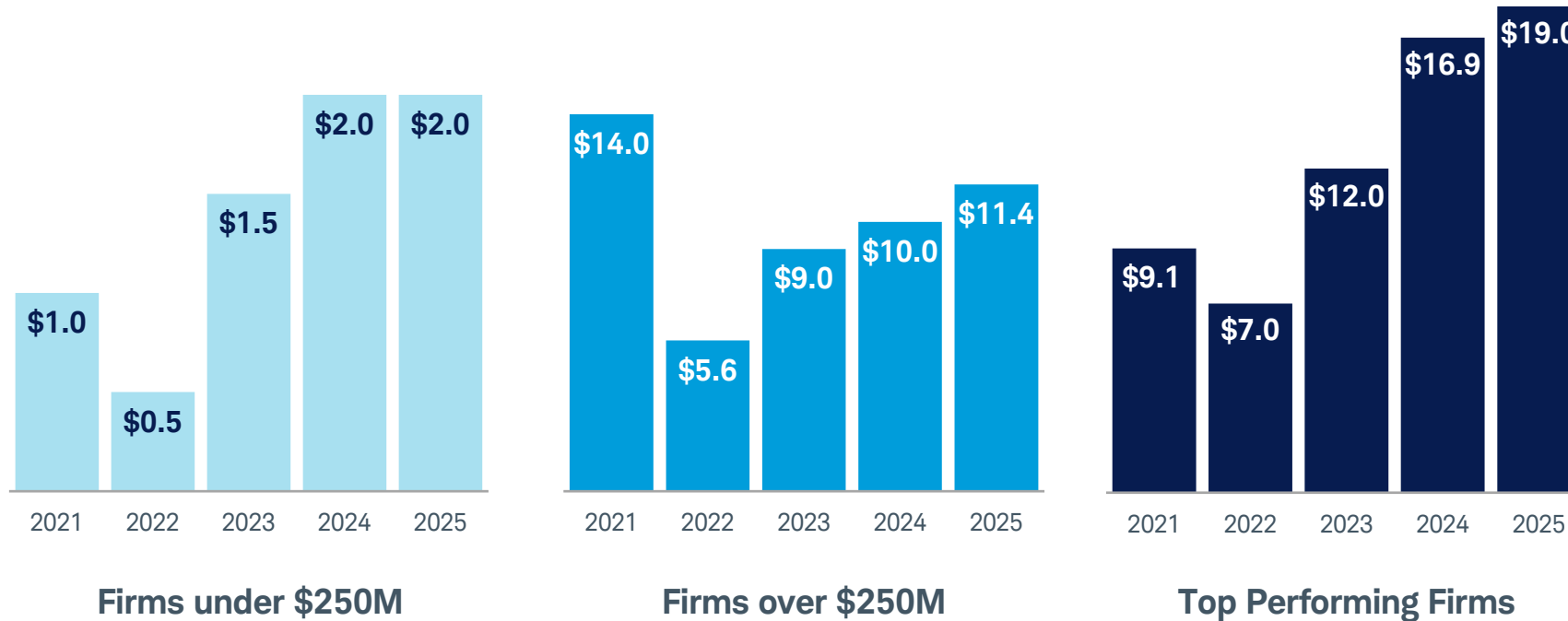
Client retention for firms across the study



Median results from the 2016-2026 RIA Benchmarking Study from Charles Schwab for all firms with \$25 million or more in AUM. Past performance is not an indicator of future results. 2026 RIA Benchmarking Study from Charles Schwab, fielded January to March 2026. Study contains self-reported data from 1,236 firms. Participant firms represent various sizes and business models categorized into peer groups by AUM.

RIAs grew assets from existing clients in 2025, especially Top Performing Firms.

Net assets from existing clients
(excluding investment performance)
In millions



Top Performing Firms gained **4.2x more** assets from existing clients than all other firms in 2025.

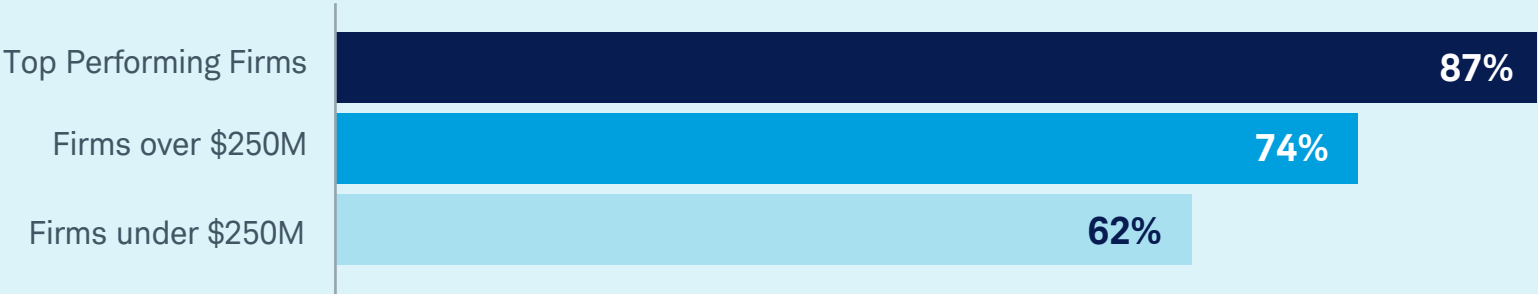
Median results. Net assets from existing clients excludes investment performance. Top Performing Firms are those that rank in the top 20% of the Firm Performance Index. The index evaluates all firms in the study according to 15 metrics to arrive at a holistic assessment of each firm's performance across key business areas. Past performance is not an indicator of future results. 2026 RIA Benchmarking Study from Charles Schwab, fielded January to March 2026. Study contains self-reported data from 1,236 firms. Participant firms represent various sizes and business models categorized into peer groups by AUM.

Top firms know who they serve and why.

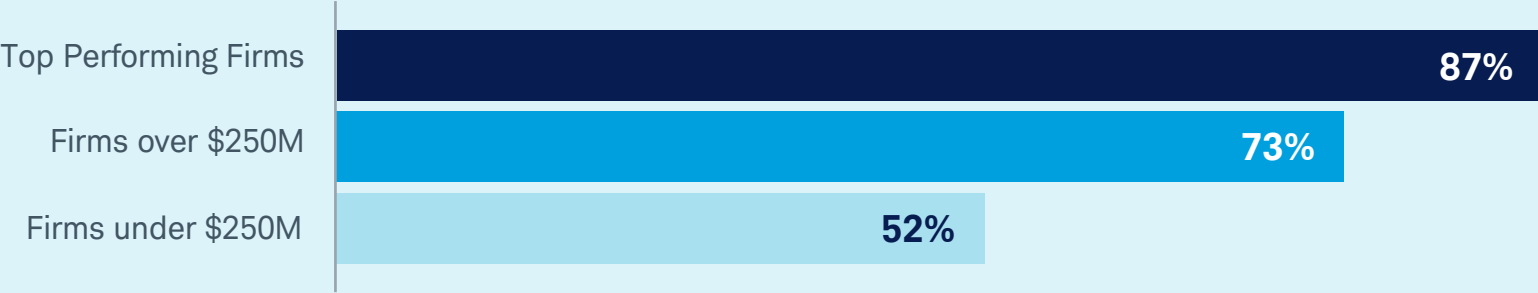


A documented ideal client persona and client value proposition align the entire firm around a strong client experience.

Firms with a documented ideal client persona (ICP)



Firms with a documented client value proposition (CVP)



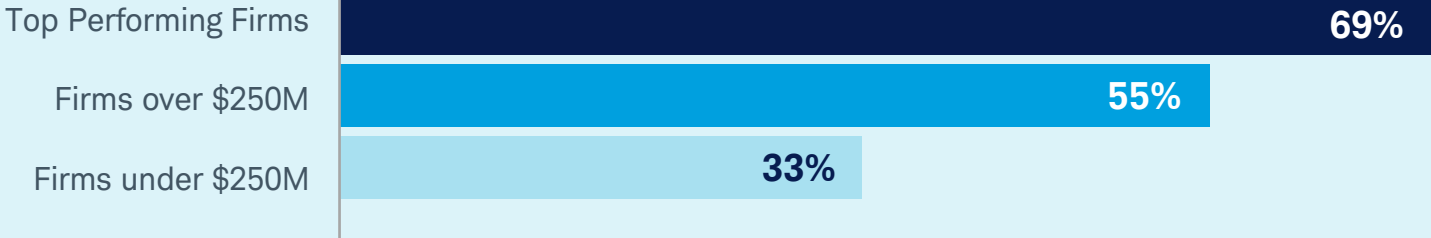
Top Performing Firms are those that rank in the top 20% of the Firm Performance Index. The index evaluates all firms in the study according to 15 metrics to arrive at a holistic assessment of each firm's performance across key business areas. Past performance is not an indicator of future results. 2026 RIA Benchmarking Study from Charles Schwab, fielded January to March 2026. Study contains self-reported data from 1,236 firms. Participant firms represent various sizes and business models categorized into peer groups by AUM.

Marketing discipline pairs planning with investment to support growth.

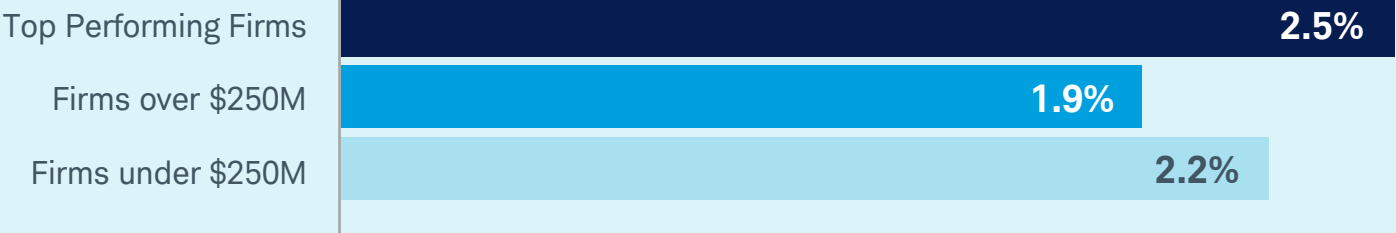


An integrated marketing plan covering activities that reach prospects and clients is essential for growth.

Firms with a documented marketing plan



Average marketing and business development spend as a percentage of revenue



Top Performing Firms are those that rank in the top 20% of the Firm Performance Index. The index evaluates all firms in the study according to 15 metrics to arrive at a holistic assessment of each firm's performance across key business areas. Past performance is not an indicator of future results. 2026 RIA Benchmarking Study from Charles Schwab, fielded January to March 2026. Study contains self-reported data from 1,236 firms. Participant firms represent various sizes and business models categorized into peer groups by AUM.

Firms with a written marketing plan, ideal client persona, and client value proposition gain more new clients and assets.

87%

More new
clients in 2025

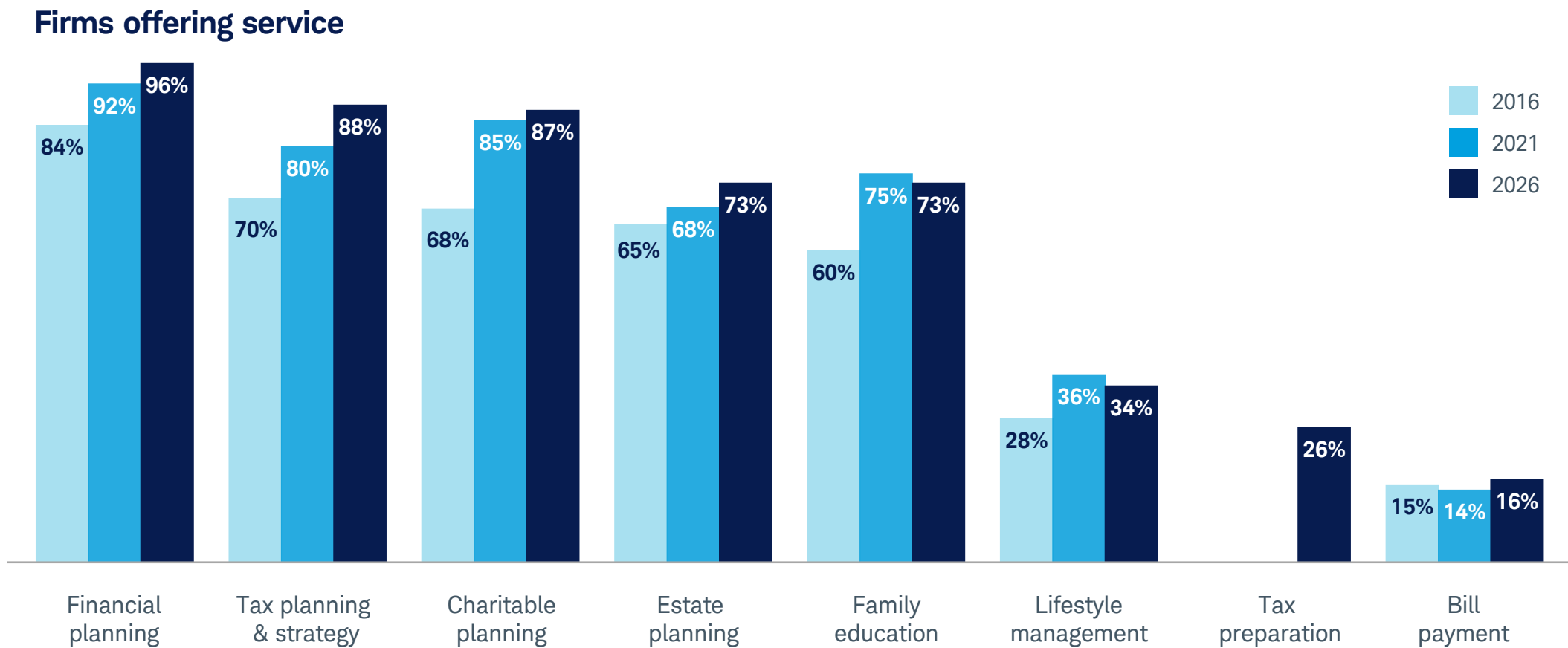


127%

More new client
assets in 2025



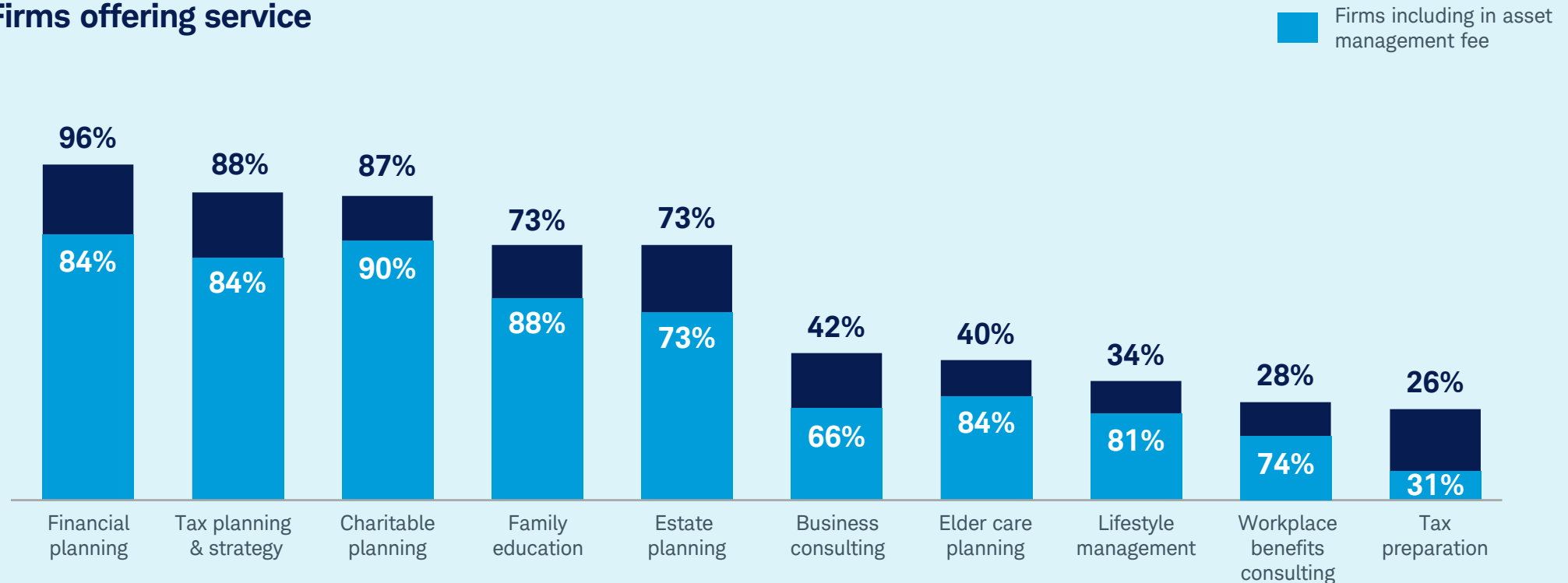
Firms have expanded services over the past decade to stay competitive and address clients’ increasingly complex needs.



Results for all firms with \$250 million or more in AUM from the 2016, 2021, and 2026 RIA Benchmarking Study from Charles Schwab. Past performance is not an indicator of future results. 2026 RIA Benchmarking Study from Charles Schwab, fielded January to March 2026. Study contains self-reported data from 1,236 firms. Participant firms represent various sizes and business models categorized into peer groups by AUM. Tax preparation response only available in the 2026 RIA Benchmarking Study from Charles Schwab.

Firms offer services to meet ideal client needs and help deepen relationships, typically including them as part of the fee.

Firms offering service

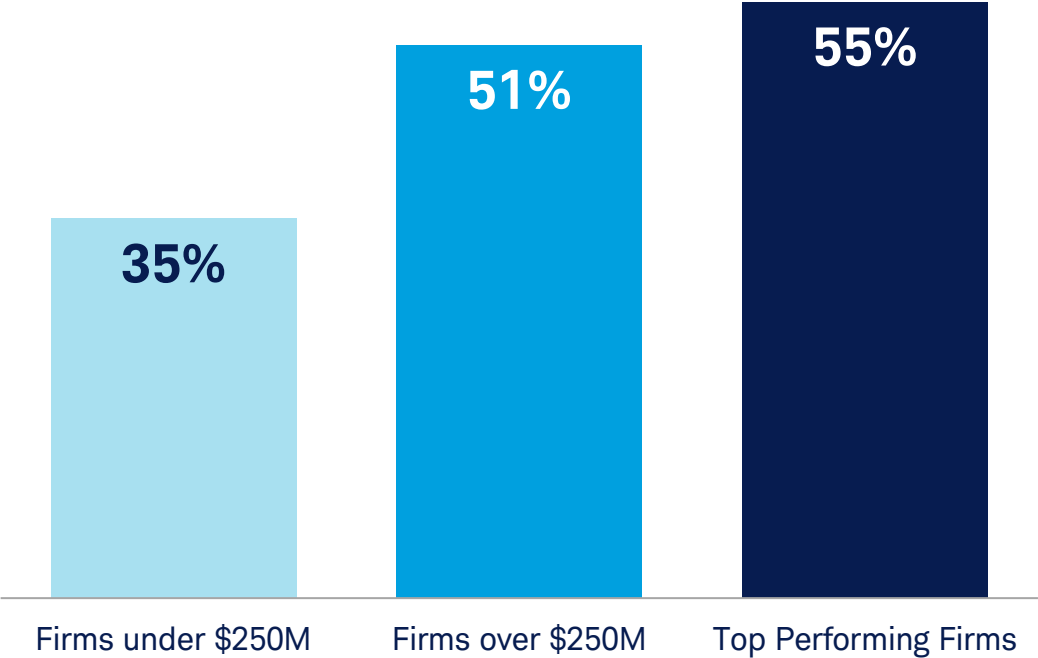


Results for all firms with \$250 million or more in AUM. Past performance is not an indicator of future results. 2026 RIA Benchmarking Study from Charles Schwab, fielded January to March 2026. Study contains self-reported data from 1,236 firms. Participant firms represent various sizes and business models categorized into peer groups by AUM.

Client segmentation can support a consistent, efficient client experience.

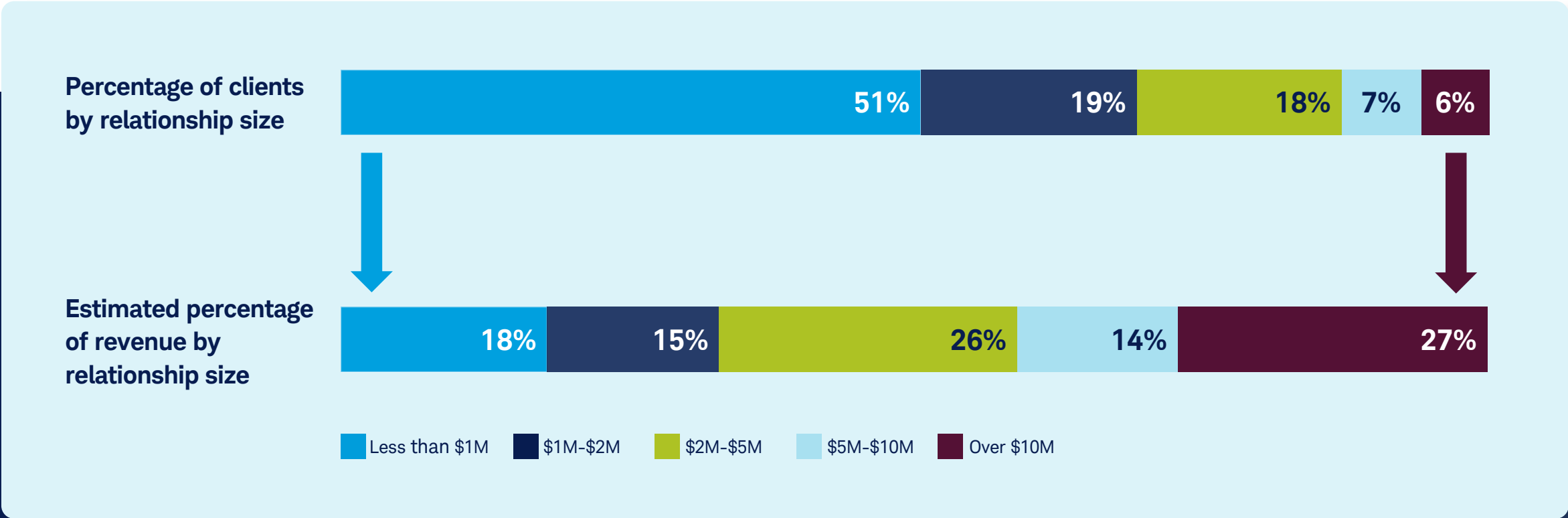
Determining what services to offer, and how to deliver them consistently and efficiently among each segment of clients, is an important part of any client segmentation strategy.

Firms with a client segmentation strategy



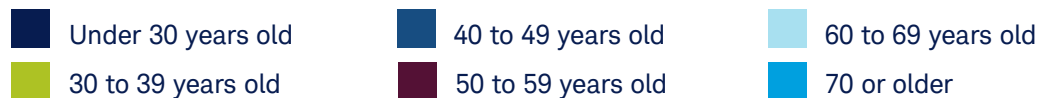
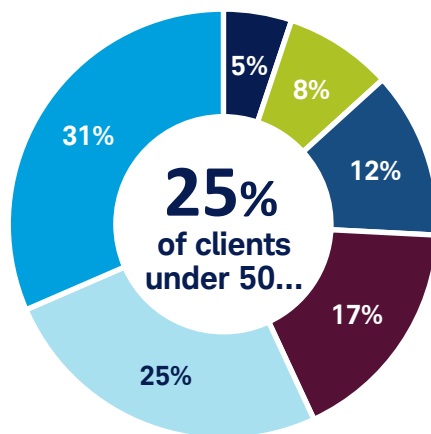
Top Performing Firms are those that rank in the top 20% of the Firm Performance Index. The index evaluates all firms in the study according to 15 metrics to arrive at a holistic assessment of each firm's performance across key business areas. Past performance is not an indicator of future results. 2026 RIA Benchmarking Study from Charles Schwab, fielded January to March 2026. Study contains self-reported data from 1,236 firms. Participant firms represent various sizes and business models categorized into peer groups by AUM.

Aligning revenue with cost to serve is essential to profitability.

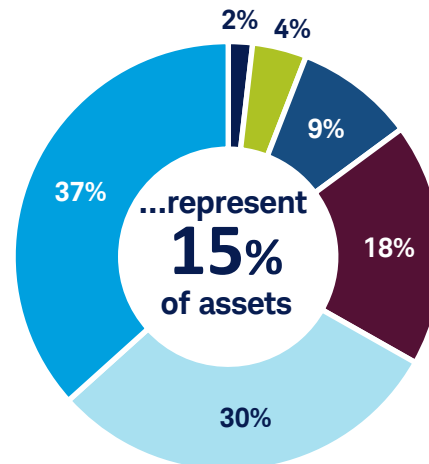


Understanding client demographics can help firms attract talent aligned with their growth plans.

Client distribution by client age



Asset distribution by client age



Family education at the forefront

73% of firms offer family education services, with 88% of those firms including it as part of their asset management fee.

GUIDING PRINCIPLES FOR ADVISORY FIRM SUCCESS



Effective planning
and execution is a
leading indicator
of success



Value is defined
through your
clients' eyes



Operational
excellence creates
greater capacity
for clients

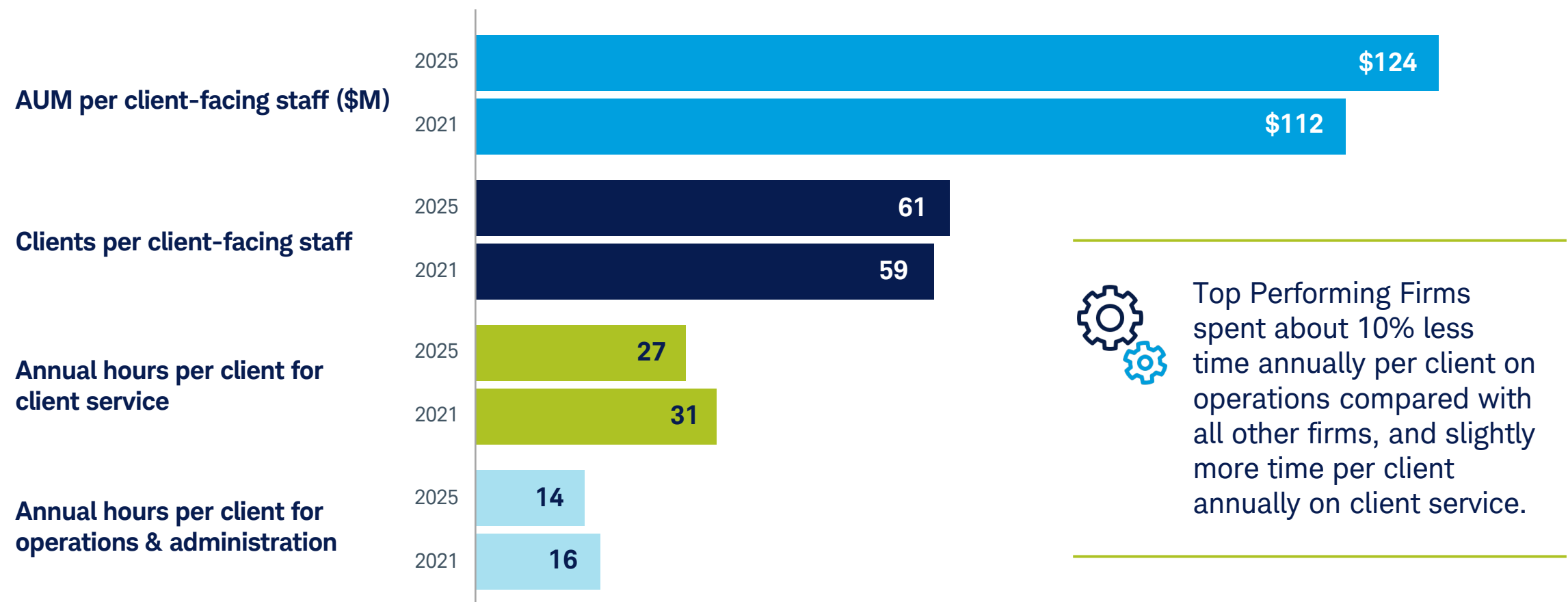


Your
reputation is
your brand



People are your
most important
asset

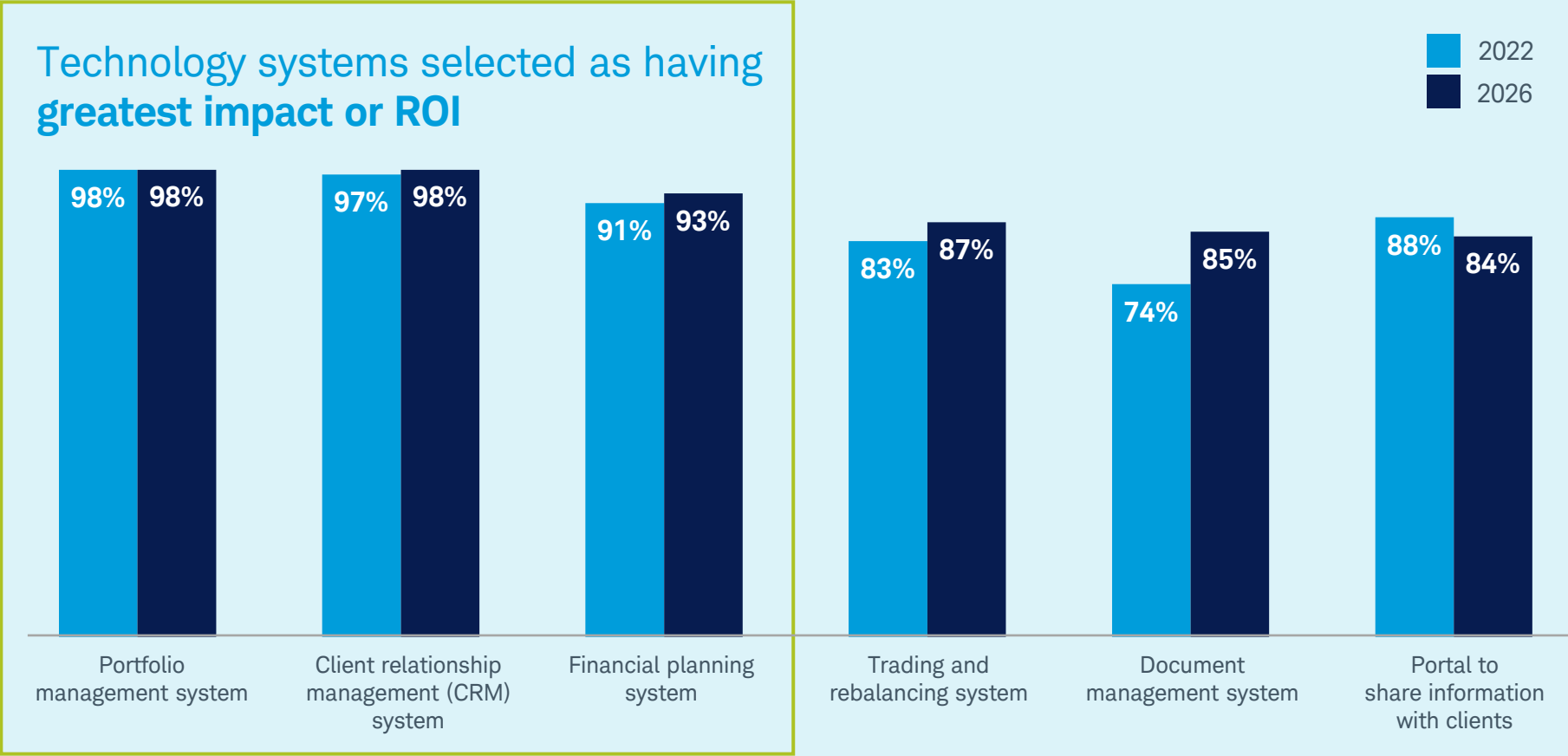
As firms have improved operational efficiency, they have realized productivity gains.



Results from the 2022 and 2026 RIA Benchmarking Study from Charles Schwab. Median results for all firms with \$250 million or more in AUM. Median results for Top Performing Firms compared to firms with \$250 million or more in AUM. Top Performing Firms are those that rank in the top 20% of the Firm Performance Index. The index evaluates all firms in the study according to 15 metrics to arrive at a holistic assessment of each firm's performance across key business areas. Past performance is not an indicator of future results. 2026 RIA Benchmarking Study from Charles Schwab, fielded January to March 2026. Study contains self-reported data from 1,236 firms. Participant firms represent various sizes and business models categorized into peer groups by AUM.

Portfolio management systems, CRMs, and financial planning systems have the greatest ROI for firms.

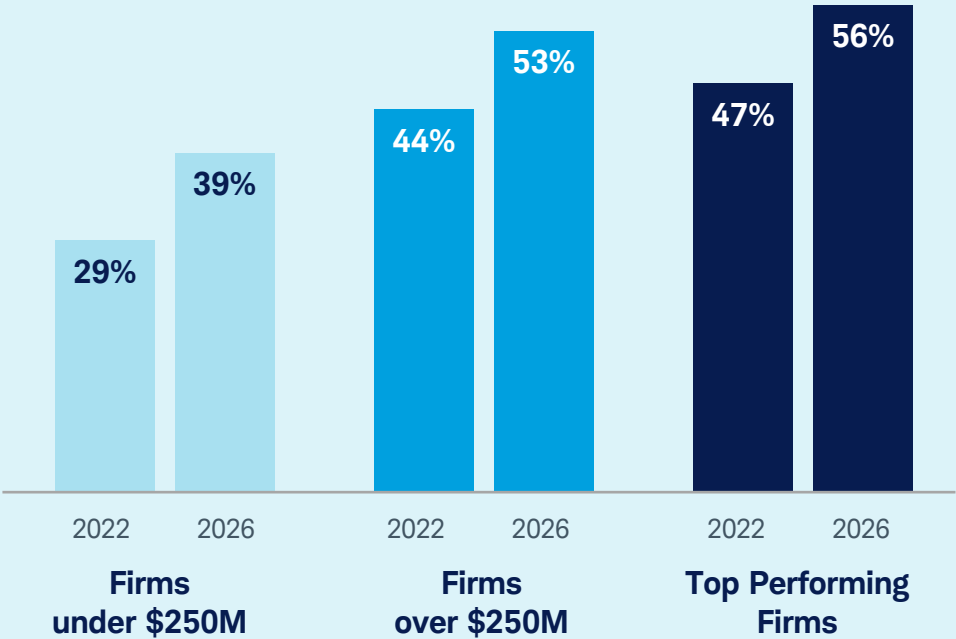
Firms using technology systems



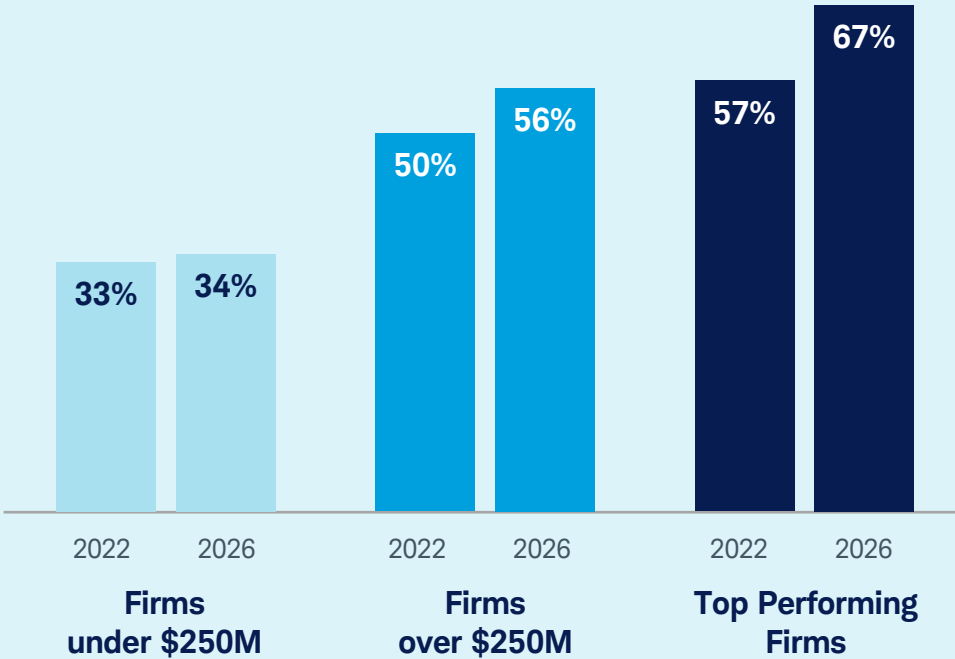
Results from the 2022 and 2026 RIA Benchmarking Study from Charles Schwab. Results for all firms with \$250 million or more in AUM. Past performance is not an indicator of future results. 2026 RIA Benchmarking Study from Charles Schwab, fielded January to March 2026. Study contains self-reported data from 1,236 firms. Participant firms represent various sizes and business models categorized into peer groups by AUM.

Top Performing Firms more often use their CRM as the central hub to serve clients more consistently.

Firms with three or more data sources or systems integrated with CRM



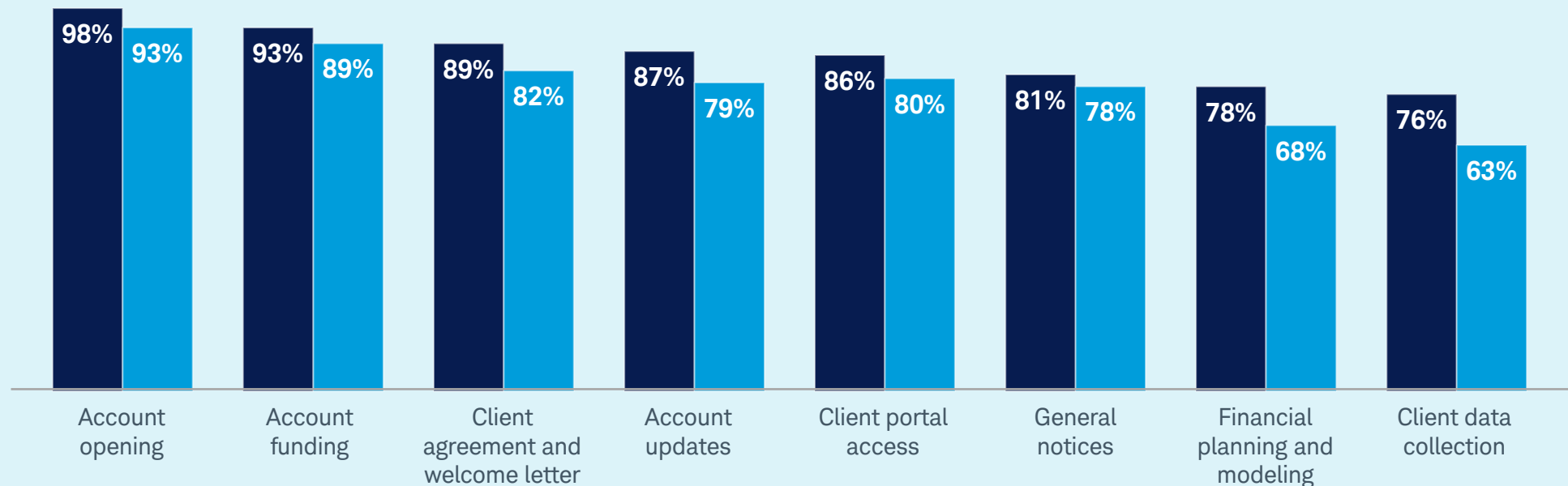
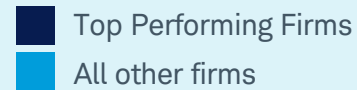
Firms with standardized workflows within CRM for over 50% of tasks



Results from the 2022 and 2026 RIA Benchmarking Study from Charles Schwab. Top Performing Firms are those that rank in the top 20% of the Firm Performance Index. The index evaluates all firms in the study according to 15 metrics to arrive at a holistic assessment of each firm's performance across key business areas. Past performance is not an indicator of future results. 2026 RIA Benchmarking Study from Charles Schwab, fielded January to March 2026. Study contains self-reported data from 1,236 firms. Participant firms represent various sizes and business models categorized into peer groups by AUM.

Digital processes can improve operational efficiency, consistency, and security, helping to reduce rework and fraud.

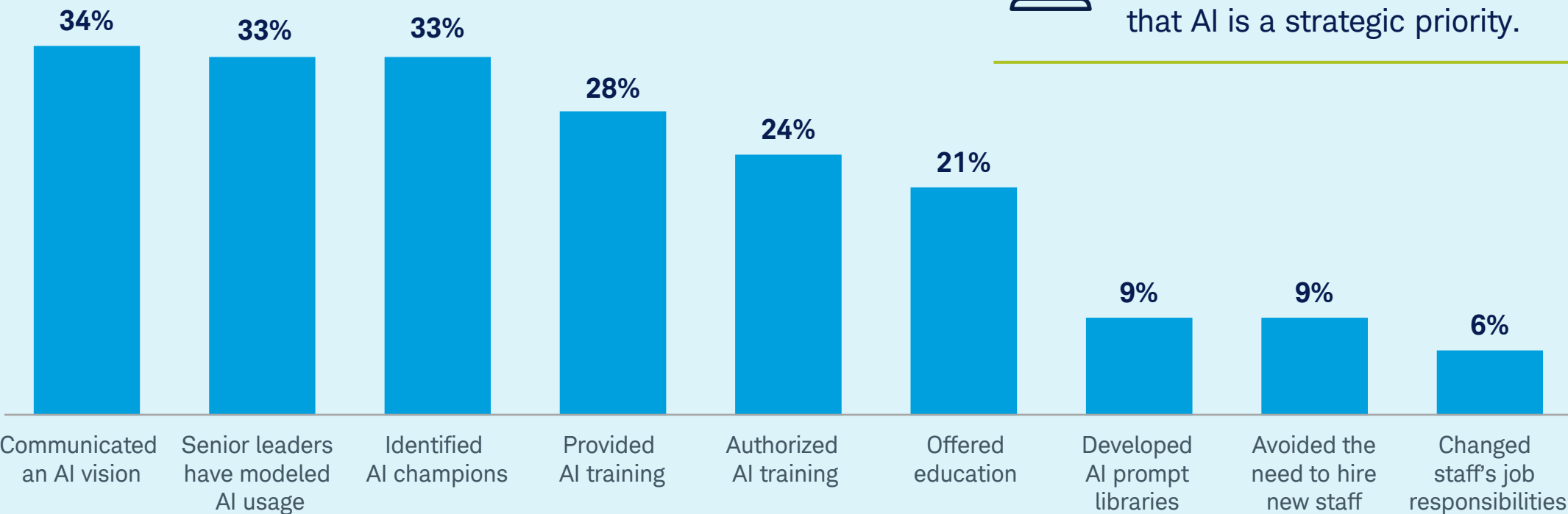
Firms that use digital processes for client workflows



Results for Top Performing Firms and all other firms. Top Performing Firms are those that rank in the top 20% of the Firm Performance Index. The index evaluates all firms in the study according to 15 metrics to arrive at a holistic assessment of each firm's performance across key business areas. Past performance is not an indicator of future results. 2026 RIA Benchmarking Study from Charles Schwab, fielded January to March 2026. Study contains self-reported data from 1,236 firms. Participant firms represent various sizes and business models categorized into peer groups by AUM.

One-third of firms are supporting AI adoption through vision, modeled use, and AI champions.

Firms acting on AI adoption



These leadership actions serve as strong management signals that AI is a strategic priority.

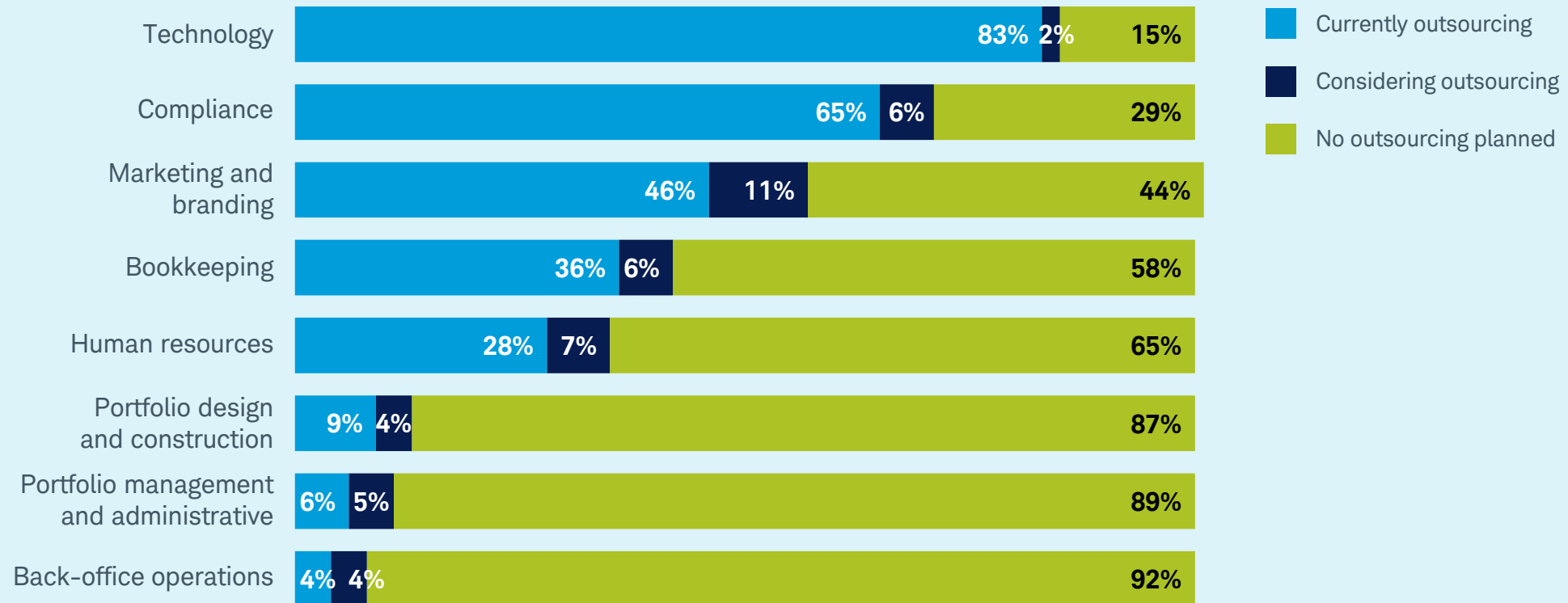
Results for all firms with \$250 million or more in AUM. Past performance is not an indicator of future results. 2026 RIA Benchmarking Study from Charles Schwab, fielded January to March 2026. Study contains self-reported data from 1,236 firms. Participant firms represent various sizes and business models categorized into peer groups by AUM.

While usage differs, 83% of firms reported using some form of AI.



Results for all firms with \$250 million or more in AUM. Past performance is not an indicator of future results. 2026 RIA Benchmarking Study from Charles Schwab, fielded January to March 2026. Study contains self-reported data from 1,236 firms. Participant firms represent various sizes and business models categorized into peer groups by AUM.

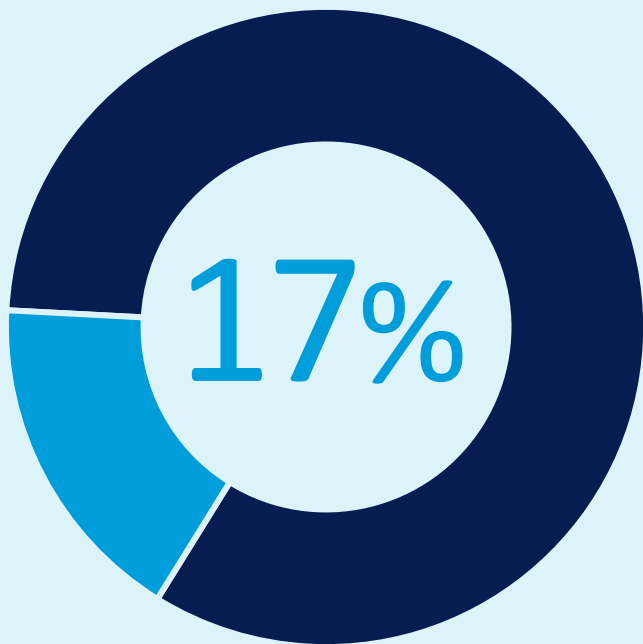
Technology leads as the most outsourced service, freeing firms to focus on client relationships and growth.



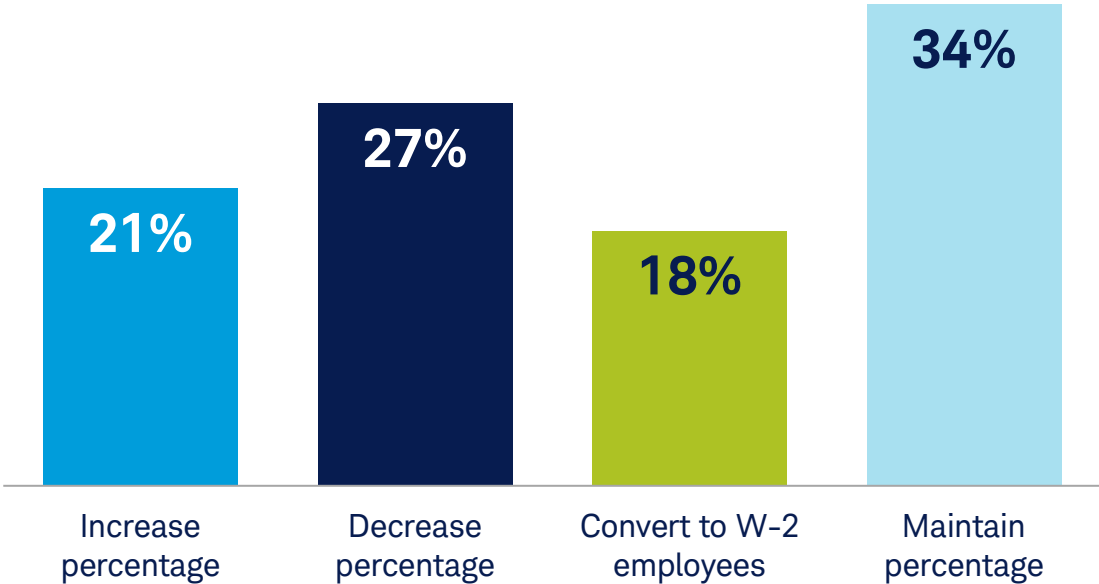
Results for all firms with \$250 million or more in AUM. May not sum to 100% due to rounding. Past performance is not an indicator of future results. 2026 RIA Benchmarking Study from Charles Schwab, fielded January to March 2026. Study contains self-reported data from 1,236 firms. Participant firms represent various sizes and business models categorized into peer groups by AUM.

Strategies for 1099 workers continue to evolve.

Firms with relationship managers that are 1099 workers



Firms' future strategy for 1099 relationship managers (next 3 years)¹



¹ Based on firms that have relationship managers that are 1099 workers.
Results for all firms with \$250 million or more in AUM. Past performance is not an indicator of future results. 2026 RIA Benchmarking Study from Charles Schwab, fielded January to March 2026. Study contains self-reported data from 1,236 firms. Participant firms represent various sizes and business models categorized into peer groups by AUM.

GUIDING PRINCIPLES FOR ADVISORY FIRM SUCCESS



Effective planning
and execution is a
leading indicator
of success



Value is defined
through your
clients' eyes



Operational
excellence creates
greater capacity
for clients



Your
reputation is
your brand

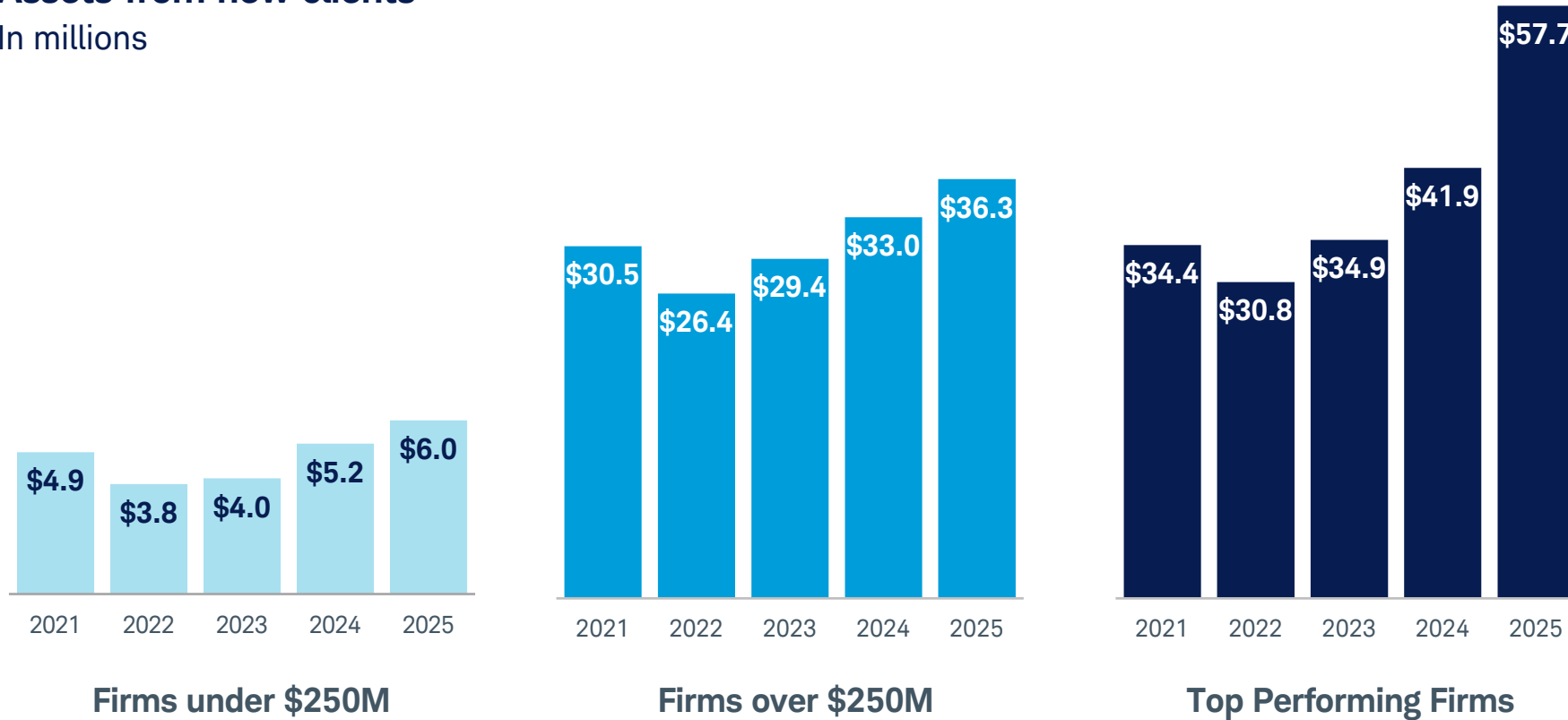


People are your
most important
asset

Firms continued their culture of new client growth, with all firms achieving five-year highs.

Assets from new clients

In millions



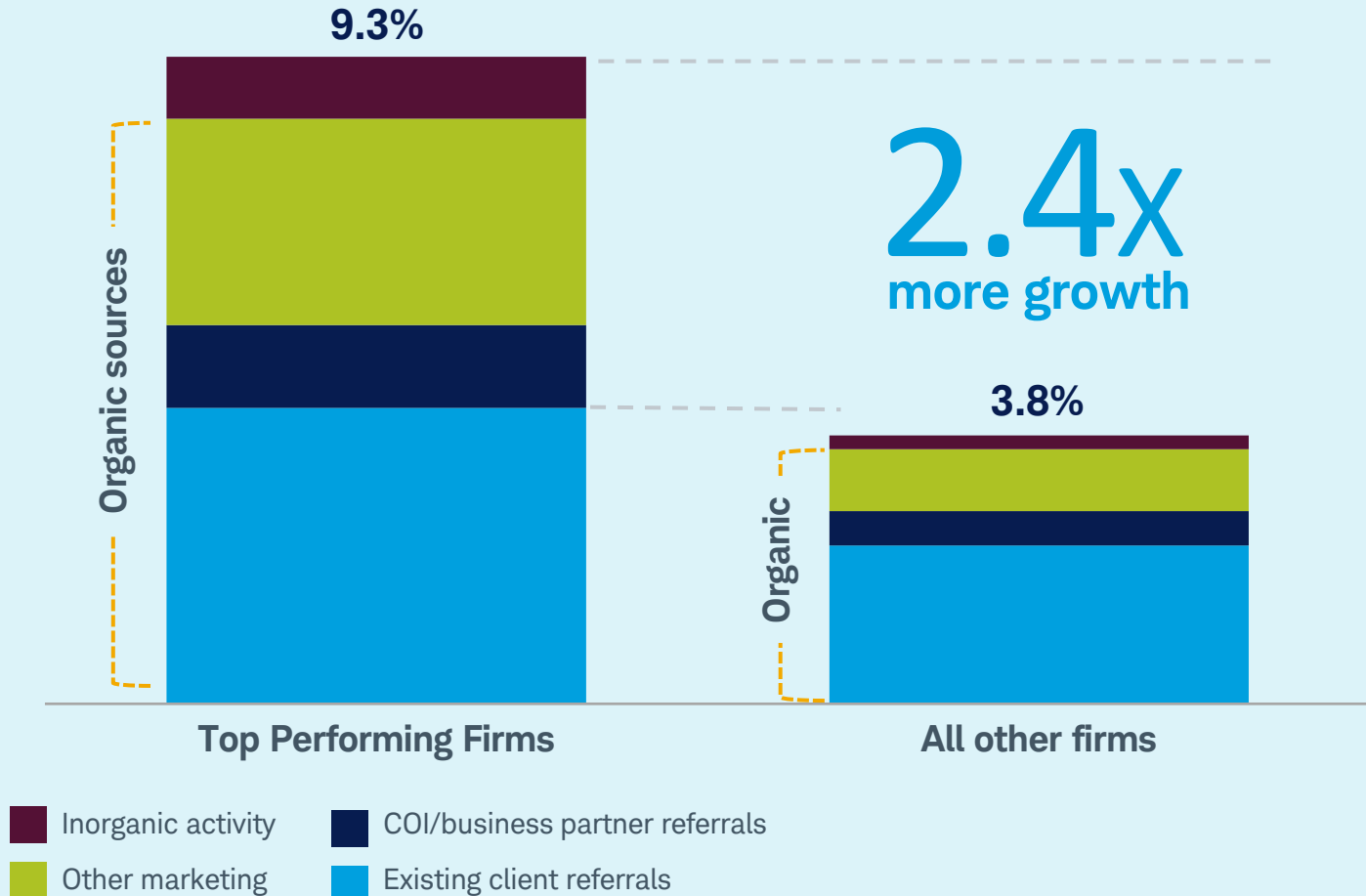
Top Performing Firms gained **2.8x more** assets from new clients than all other firms in 2025.

Median results. Top Performing Firms are those that rank in the top 20% of the Firm Performance Index. The index evaluates all firms in the study according to 15 metrics to arrive at a holistic assessment of each firm's performance across key business areas. Past performance is not an indicator of future results. 2026 RIA Benchmarking Study from Charles Schwab, fielded January to March 2026. Study contains self-reported data from 1,236 firms. Participant firms represent various sizes and business models categorized into peer groups by AUM.

Intentional referral and brand-driven efforts pay off.

Top Performing Firms drove strong new client acquisitions through marketing and referrals.

Asset growth in 2025 from new clients by source



Results for Top Performing Firms and all other firms. Top Performing Firms are those that rank in the top 20% of the Firm Performance Index. The index evaluates all firms in the study according to 15 metrics to arrive at a holistic assessment of each firm's performance across key business areas. Past performance is not an indicator of future results. 2026 RIA Benchmarking Study from Charles Schwab, fielded January to March 2026. Study contains self-reported data from 1,236 firms. Participant firms represent various sizes and business models categorized into peer groups by AUM.

Referrals are the backbone of organic growth, yet fewer than half of firms document referral plans.

Firms with a documented referral plan for **existing clients**

Top Performing Firms

52%

Firms over \$250M

44%

Firms under \$250M

21%

Firms with a documented referral plan for **centers of influence**

Top Performing Firms

36%

Firms over \$250M

30%

Firms under \$250M

13%

Top Performing Firms are those that rank in the top 20% of the Firm Performance Index. The index evaluates all firms in the study according to 15 metrics to arrive at a holistic assessment of each firm's performance across key business areas. Past performance is not an indicator of future results. 2026 RIA Benchmarking Study from Charles Schwab, fielded January to March 2026. Study contains self-reported data from 1,236 firms. Participant firms represent various sizes and business models categorized into peer groups by AUM.

Firms with referral plans achieved stronger results from those channels in 2025 than those without.

Firms with **existing client** referral plans

1.5x more new clients
generated from existing
client referrals

1.6x more new client assets
generated from existing
client referrals

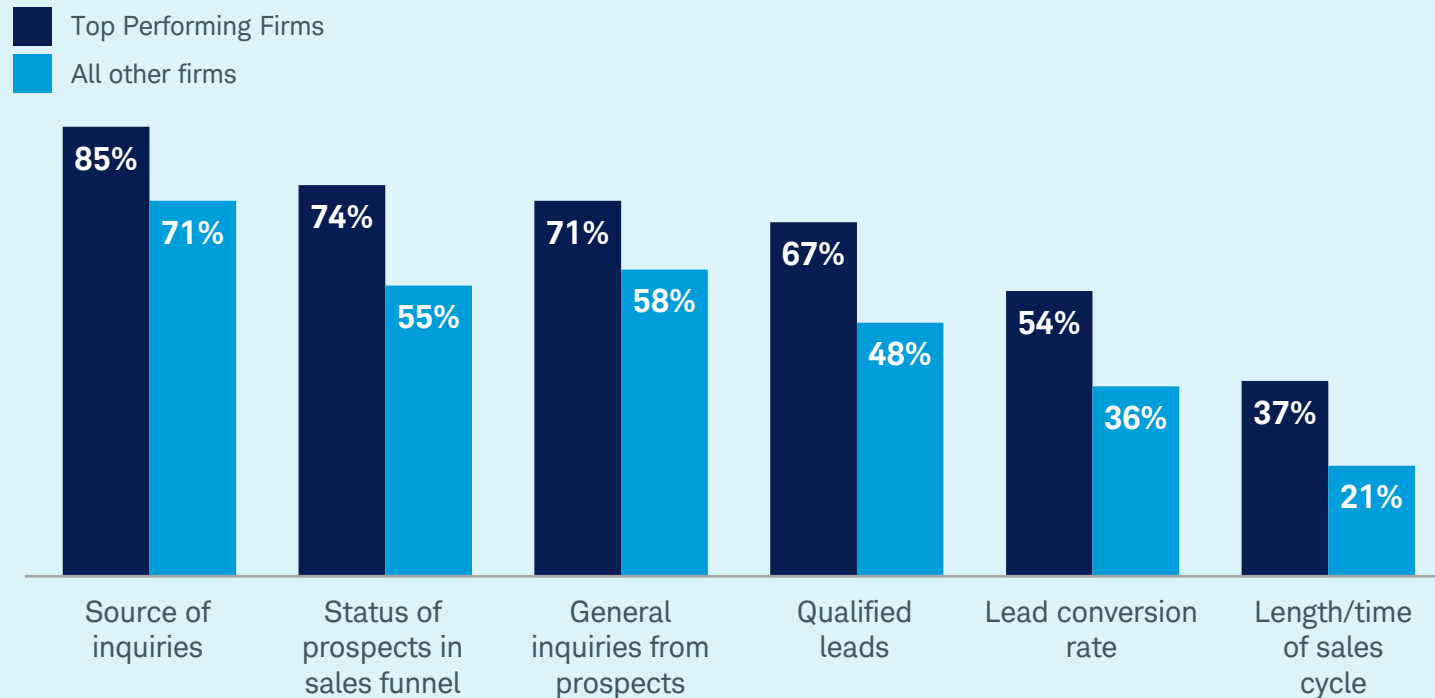
Firms with **business partner** referral plans

1.6x more new clients
generated from business
partner referrals

1.7x more new client assets
generated from business
partner referrals

New-client growth tracking reflects growth maturity.

Elements tracked to measure progress toward new client goals



By tracking sources, firms can identify which channels consistently produce higher-quality prospects and concentrate their efforts and resources accordingly.

Top Performing Firms are those that rank in the top 20% of the Firm Performance Index. The index evaluates all firms in the study according to 15 metrics to arrive at a holistic assessment of each firm's performance across key business areas. Past performance is not an indicator of future results. 2026 RIA Benchmarking Study from Charles Schwab, fielded January to March 2026. Study contains self-reported data from 1,236 firms. Participant firms represent various sizes and business models categorized into peer groups by AUM.

GUIDING PRINCIPLES FOR ADVISORY FIRM SUCCESS



Effective planning
and execution is a
leading indicator
of success



Value is defined
through your
clients' eyes



Operational
excellence creates
greater capacity
for clients



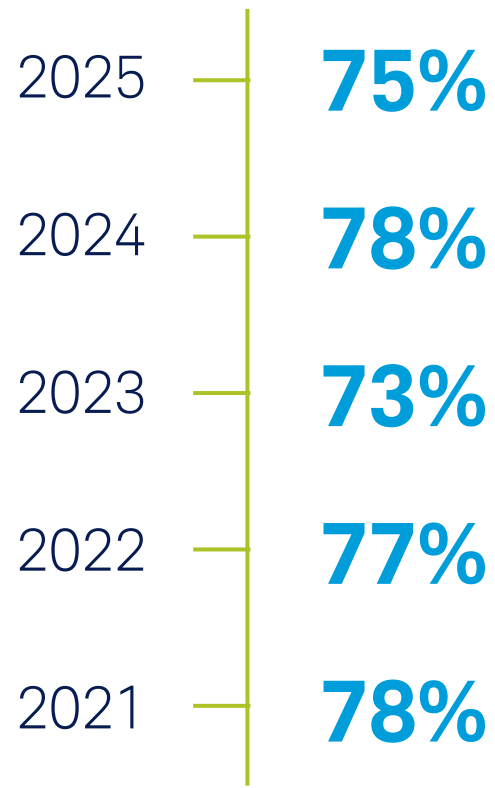
Your
reputation is
your brand



People are your
most important
asset

Seventy-five percent of firms hired in 2025, highlighting the need for talent.

Firms that hired each year



Median firm hired 2 staff for new roles added in 2025.

Top recruiting channels used:

Personal + professional networks	56% of firms
Colleges/universities	36%
RIAs	28%
Non-financial professional services firms	19%

Adding talent continues to be a focus for most firms.

Over the next five years,

Median firm will need to hire

4 new roles

Median Top Performing Firm will need to hire

7 new roles

Based on current growth rates and the number of RIAs, the industry will need to hire

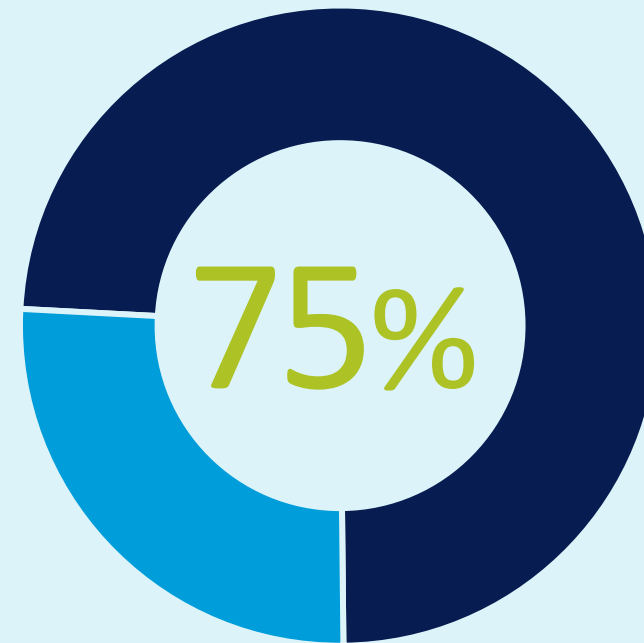
more than 70,000 new staff

over the next five years, without accounting for any attrition, retirements, new firms or AI productivity gains.

¹ Results for all firms with \$250 million or more in AUM.

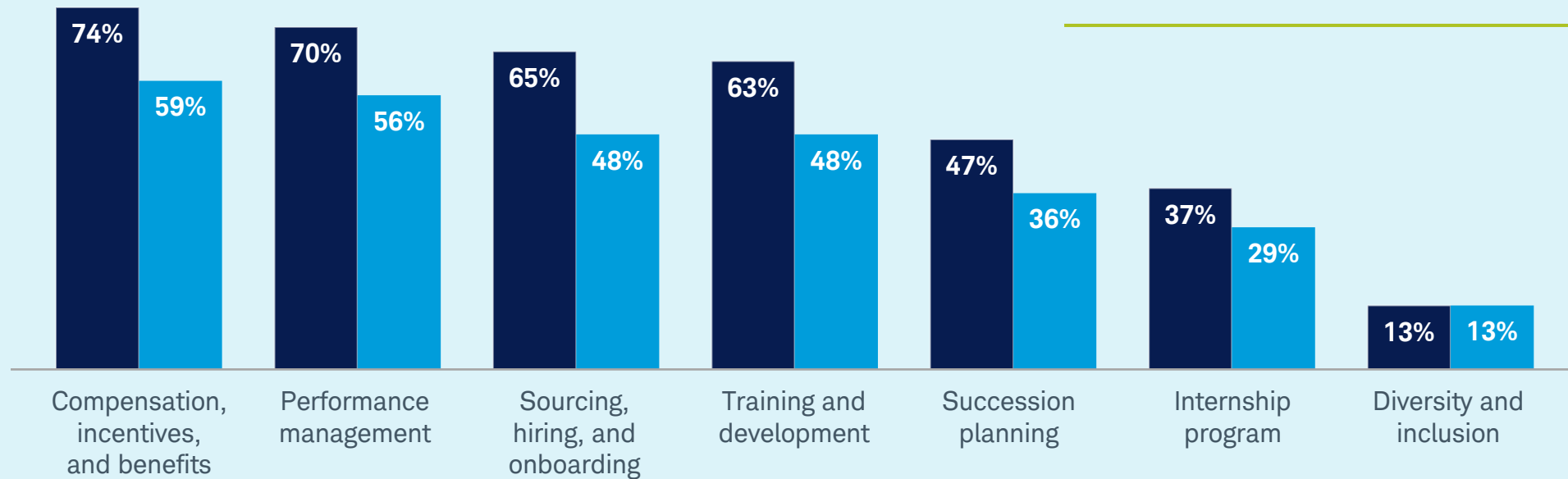
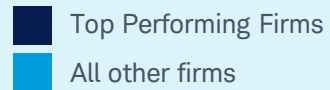
Hiring projections based on all firms with \$25 million or more in AUM and Top Performing Firms which are those that rank in the top 20% of the Firm Performance Index. The index evaluates all firms in the study according to 15 metrics to arrive at a holistic assessment of each firm's performance across key business areas. Past performance is not an indicator of future results. 2026 RIA Benchmarking Study from Charles Schwab, fielded January to March 2026. Study contains self-reported data from 1,236 firms. Participant firms represent various sizes and business models categorized into peer groups by AUM.

Firms that plan to hire in 2026¹



A documented talent strategy can help RIAs align talent with growth objectives.

Talent strategy documented processes



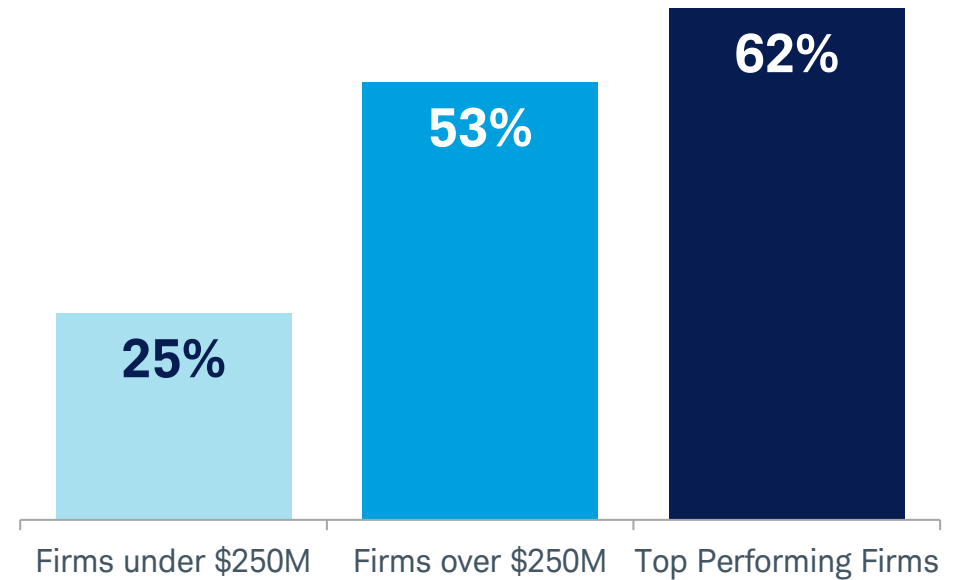
Top Performing Firms more often have defined career paths compared with all other firms.

Top Performing Firms are those that rank in the top 20% of the Firm Performance Index. The index evaluates all firms in the study according to 15 metrics to arrive at a holistic assessment of each firm's performance across key business areas. Past performance is not an indicator of future results. 2026 RIA Benchmarking Study from Charles Schwab, fielded January to March 2026. Study contains self-reported data from 1,236 firms. Participant firms represent various sizes and business models categorized into peer groups by AUM.

Adoption of employee value propositions has grown nearly 10% over four years.¹

An employee value proposition (EVP) is a set of offerings the firm provides to staff in return for the skills and experiences employees bring to the firm.

Firms with a documented EVP

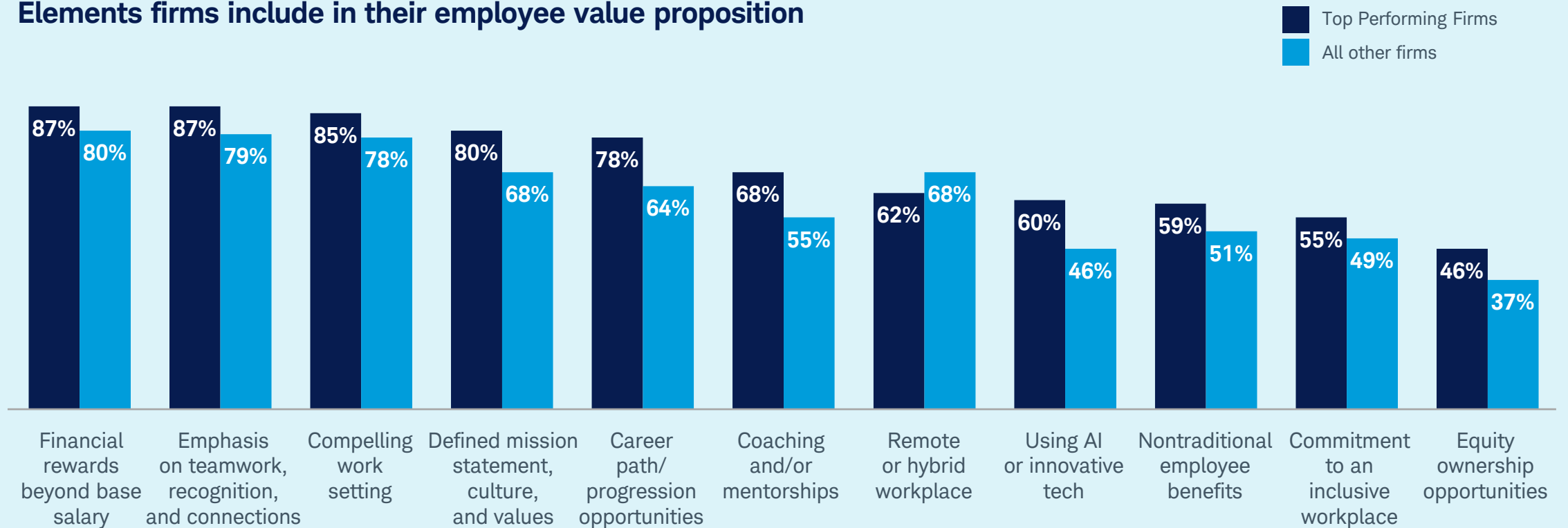


¹ Results for all firms with \$250 million or more in AUM from the 2022 and 2026 RIA Benchmarking Study.

Top Performing Firms are those that rank in the top 20% of the Firm Performance Index. The index evaluates all firms in the study according to 15 metrics to arrive at a holistic assessment of each firm's performance across key business areas. Past performance is not an indicator of future results. 2026 RIA Benchmarking Study from Charles Schwab, fielded January to March 2026. Study contains self-reported data from 1,236 firms. Participant firms represent various sizes and business models categorized into peer groups by AUM.

A clear EVP defines the value exchange between employee and firm.

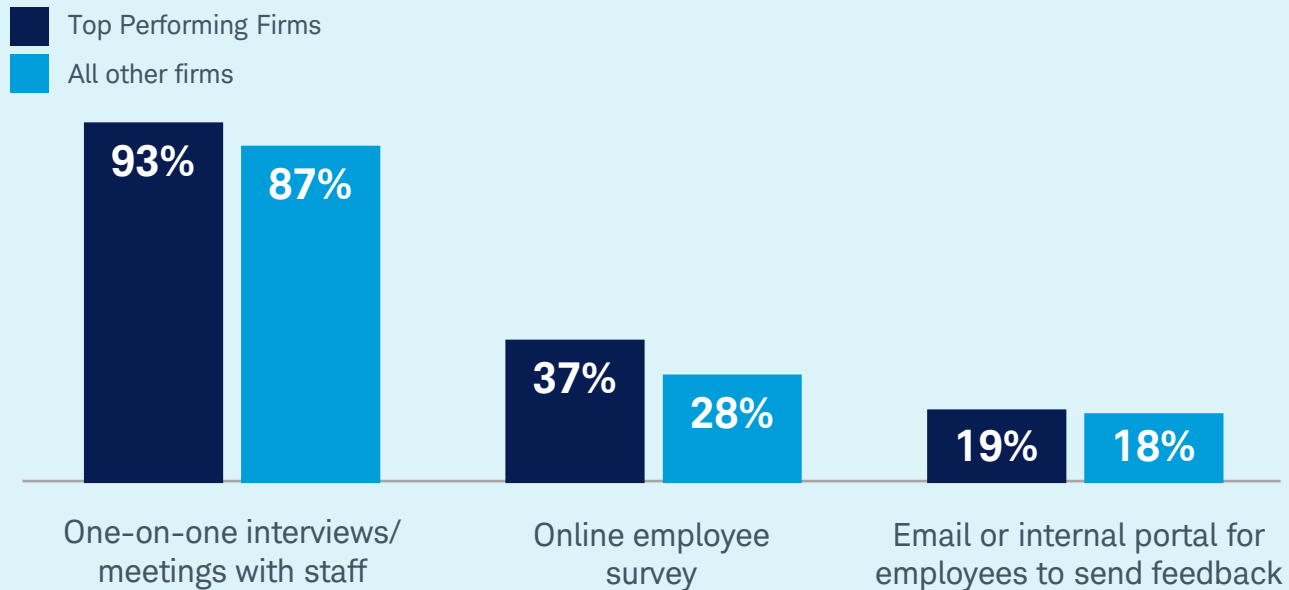
Elements firms include in their employee value proposition



Results for Top Performing Firms and all other firms. Top Performing Firms are those that rank in the top 20% of the Firm Performance Index. The index evaluates all firms in the study according to 15 metrics to arrive at a holistic assessment of each firm's performance across key business areas. Past performance is not an indicator of future results. 2026 RIA Benchmarking Study from Charles Schwab, fielded January to March 2026. Study contains self-reported data from 1,236 firms. Participant firms represent various sizes and business models categorized into peer groups by AUM.

Staff feedback can inform both engagement and the employee value proposition.

Methods used to collect feedback from staff

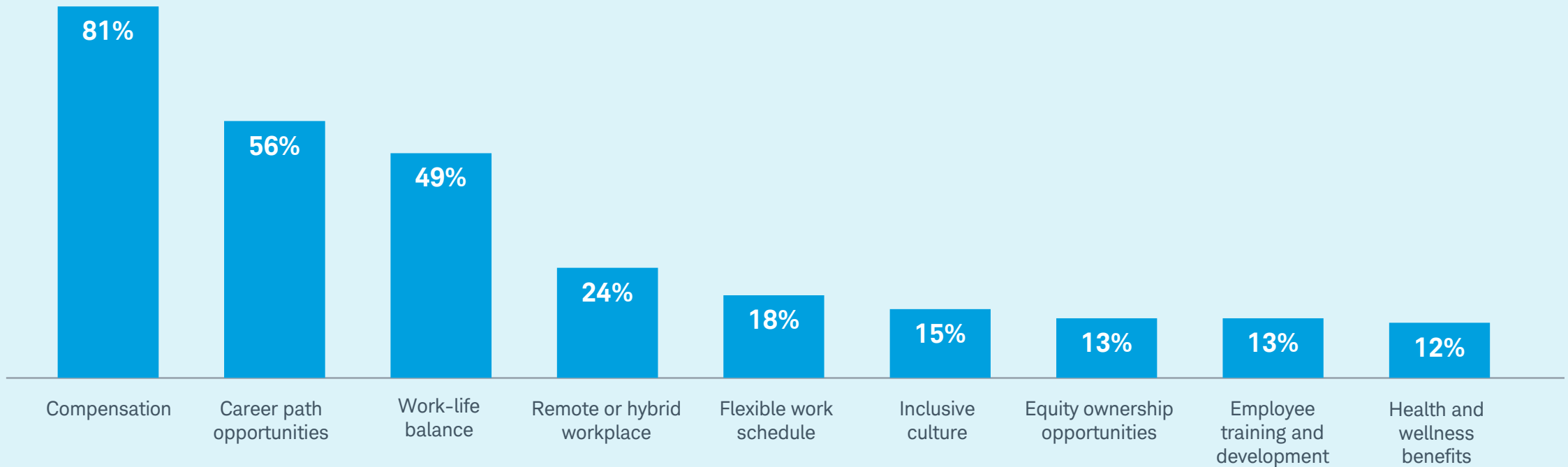


96% of Top Performing Firms collect staff feedback compared with 89% of all other firms.

Results for Top Performing Firms and all other firms. Top Performing Firms are those that rank in the top 20% of the Firm Performance Index. The index evaluates all firms in the study according to 15 metrics to arrive at a holistic assessment of each firm's performance across key business areas. Past performance is not an indicator of future results. 2026 RIA Benchmarking Study from Charles Schwab, fielded January to March 2026. Study contains self-reported data from 1,236 firms. Participant firms represent various sizes and business models categorized into peer groups by AUM.

Understanding candidates' top priorities can help firms attract and retain top talent in a competitive market.

Candidate priorities in hiring (advisor perspective)



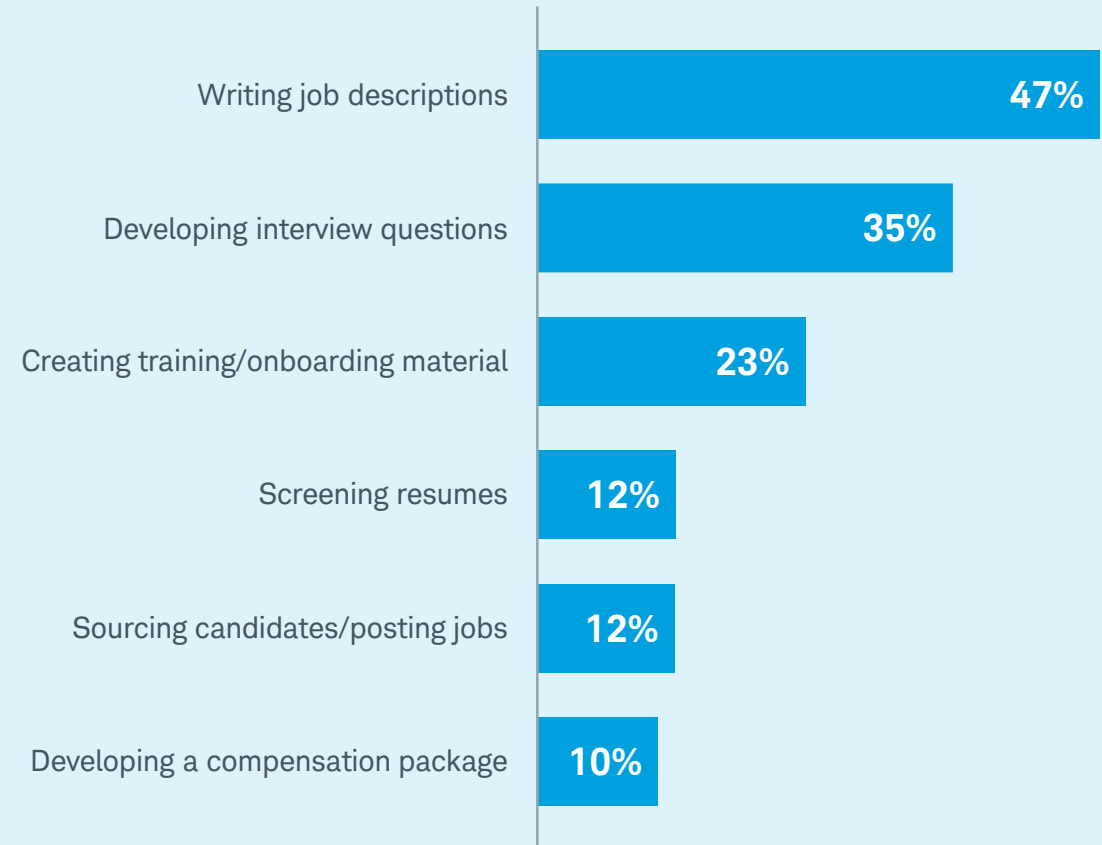
Results for all firms with \$250 million or more in AUM that selected offering as a top 3 priority. Past performance is not an indicator of future results. 2026 RIA Benchmarking Study from Charles Schwab, fielded January to March 2026. Study contains self-reported data from 1,236 firms. Participant firms represent various sizes and business models categorized into peer groups by AUM.

AI is entering the hiring process.



Firms are beginning to leverage AI to support recruitment.

Recruiting processes supported by AI



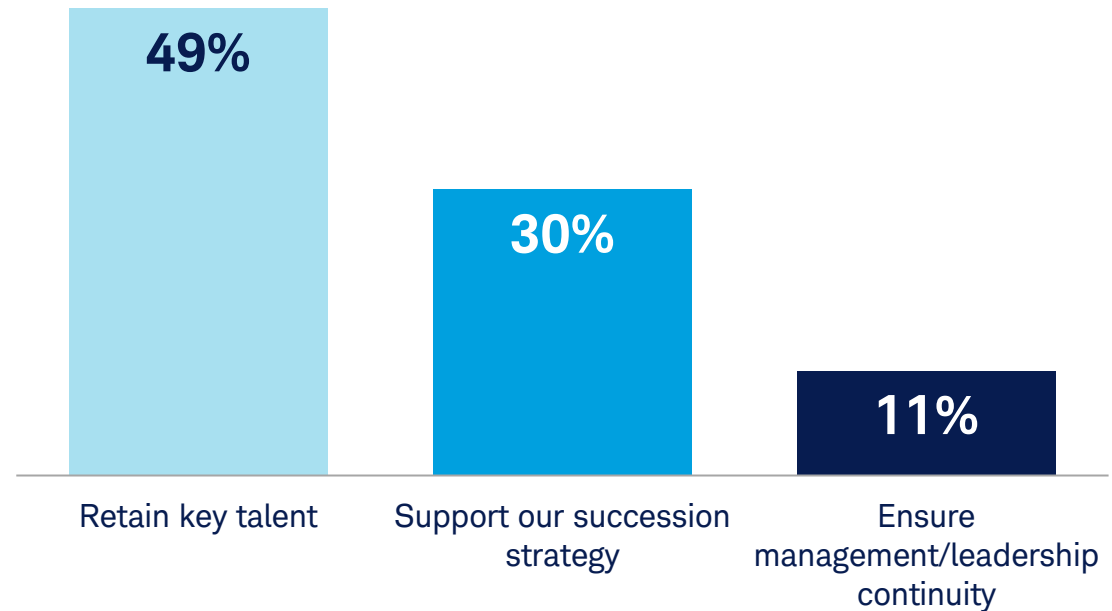
Results for all firms with \$250 million or more in AUM. Past performance is not an indicator of future results. 2026 RIA Benchmarking Study from Charles Schwab, fielded January to March 2026. Study contains self-reported data from 1,236 firms. Participant firms represent various sizes and business models categorized into peer groups by AUM.

Sharing equity can support talent retention, succession, and alignment.



One-third of firms have a documented path to equity ownership.

Primary reason for sharing equity¹



¹ Based on firms that offer equity ownership to non-founders.

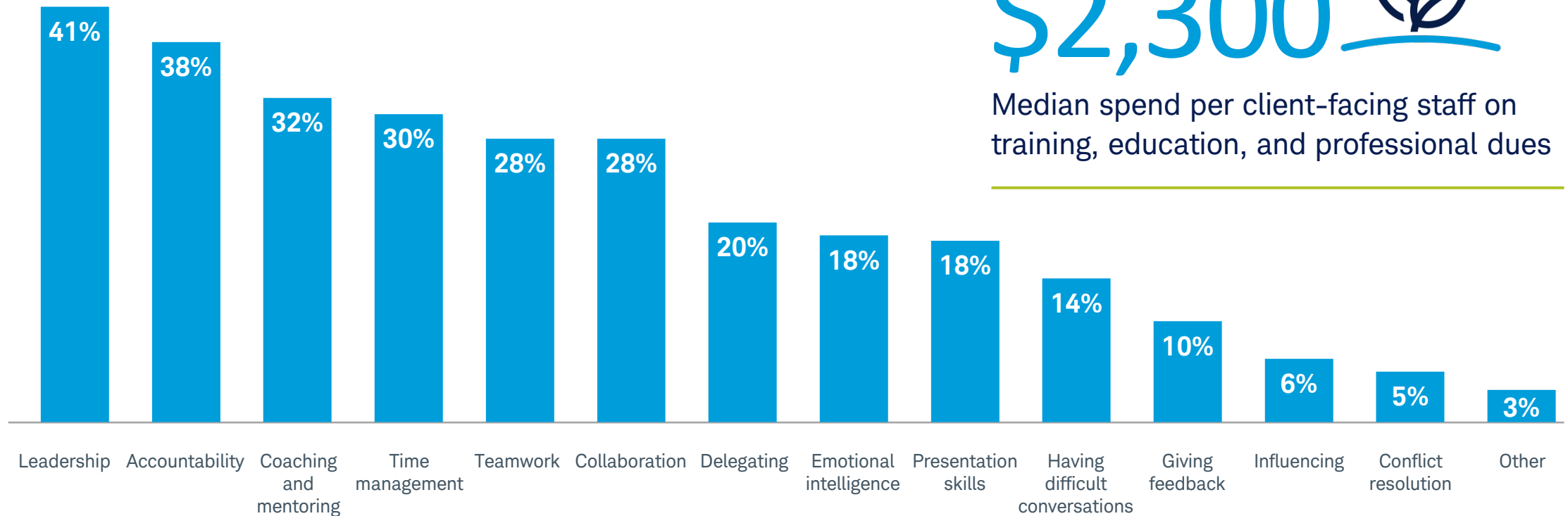
Coaching and developing staff supports engagement and helps create an enduring firm.



Results for all firms with \$250 million or more in AUM. Past performance is not an indicator of future results. 2026 RIA Benchmarking Study from Charles Schwab, fielded January to March 2026. Study contains self-reported data from 1,236 firms. Participant firms represent various sizes and business models categorized into peer groups by AUM.

Firms cultivating soft skills can strengthen their culture and gain a competitive advantage.

Top soft-skills development priorities for firms



\$2,300 
Median spend per client-facing staff on training, education, and professional dues

Results for all firms with \$250 million or more in AUM that selected soft skill as a top 3 priority over the next three years. Past performance is not an indicator of future results. 2026 RIA Benchmarking Study from Charles Schwab, fielded January to March 2026. Study contains self-reported data from 1,236 firms. Participant firms represent various sizes and business models categorized into peer groups by AUM.

Important information

This material is intended for general informational and educational purposes only.

This material is for institutional investor use only. This material may not be forwarded or made available, in part or in whole, to any party that is not an institutional investor. RIAs are not affiliated with, employed by, recommended, endorsed, or sponsored by Schwab. Experiences expressed are no guarantee of future performance or success and may not be representative of you or your experience.

Study materials, including your customized report, may not be used to train, create, develop, tune, or otherwise improve Artificial Intelligence or machine learning.

About the 2026 RIA Benchmarking Study from Charles Schwab

Schwab designed the RIA Benchmarking Study to capture insights in the RIA industry based on survey responses from individual firms. The 2026 study provides information on topics such as asset and revenue growth, sources of new clients, products and pricing, staffing, compensation, marketing, technology, and financial performance. Fielded from January to March 2026, the study contains self-reported data from 1,236 firms that custody their assets with Schwab and represents over \$2.5 trillion in assets under management, making this the leading study in the RIA industry. Schwab did not independently verify or validate the self-reported information. Participant firms represent various sizes and business models. The study is part of Schwab Business Consulting and Education, a practice management offering for RIAs. Grounded in the best practices of leading independent advisory firms, Business Consulting and Education provides insight, guidance, tools, and resources to help RIAs strategically manage and grow their firms.

Past performance is not an indicator of future results.

The Firm Performance Index evaluates firms in the study according to 15 metrics that align with the Guiding Principles for Advisory Firm Success, to arrive at a holistic assessment of each firm's performance across key business areas. It provides comprehensive comparisons for all firms participating in the study, not just within a peer group. The metrics in the Firm Performance Index measure growth in clients, assets and revenue; client attrition; staff attrition; operating margin; time spent on client service; time spent on operations; standardized workflows; written strategic plan and succession plan; and ideal client persona and client value proposition. The Firm Performance Index is calculated among all firms in the study without regard to assets under management or firm type. Firms that rank in the top 20% of the index are included in the Top Performing Firms.

Schwab Advisor Services™ provides custody, trading, and the support services of Charles Schwab & Co., Inc. (“Schwab”), member SIPC, to independent investment advisors and Charles Schwab Investment Management, Inc. (“CSIM”). Independent investment advisors are not owned by, affiliated with, or supervised by Schwab.

©2026 Charles Schwab & Co., Inc. All rights reserved. Member SIPC

JUT (0726-E34X)